

Five Little Indians



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF MICHELLE GOOD

Michelle Good was born in British Columbia to a Cree mother and a French and English father, both of whom had roots in Saskatchewan. Through her mother's side, Good is a member of the Red Pheasant Cree Nation in Saskatchewan. Her family tree includes Big Bear, a 19th-century Cree chief notable for his resistance to signing a treaty by which the Canadian government extended its claim on Cree Nation lands, as well as for his participation in an armed rebellion against the Canadian government by Cree and the Assiniboine in the late 1880s. Although Good escaped the Canadian residential school system herself, both her mother and her maternal grandmother were survivors, and at the age of 13, Good was taken from her parents and placed into the foster care system as part of efforts in the 1960s to assimilate Indigenous children. After finishing her high school equivalent, she spent many years working with Indigenous organizations before pursuing a law degree in her early 40s. In her career as a lawyer, she advocated for and represented residential school survivors for 14 years—while also pursuing a Master of Fine Arts in creative writing. She earned her MFA in 2014 at the age of 58. In addition to *Five Little Indians*—which won multiple awards on its publication—Good has published a book of essays about the experiences of Indigenous people in Canada, as well as many individual poems, essays, and articles.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

The Canadian residential school system was officially established in 1894, when the Canadian government mandated that all Indigenous children had to attend day schools, industrial schools, or residential schools, although white settlers—frequently Catholic missionaries—had been operating boarding schools for the purpose of destroying Indigenous culture and assimilating Indigenous children since the early 17th century. So many Indigenous children were forcibly removed from their families and placed into the residential school or foster care systems in between the late 1950s and early 1980s that the period has subsequently been named the “Sixties Scoop.” During this time, the encroachment of welfare workers onto Canadian Indian reserves, in conjunction with poor training and racist assumptions led to the government taking thousands of children from their families. The last residential school closed in 1996, and as survivors’ stories began to circulate more and more widely, the Canadian government established the Truth and Reconciliation Commission in 2008 and the 2013 establishment of Truth and

Reconciliation Day on September 30th.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

An avid reader for much of her life, Michelle Good cites Ethel Wilson’s 1954 *Swamp Angel* as one of her personal influences. This classic of Canadian fiction shares themes of feminism, resilience, and female redemption with *Five Little Indians*. Michelle Good’s work also shows the influence of Louise Erdrich, another Indigenous North American author whose stories often deal with the fraught history of settler colonialism. Erdrich’s 2008 novel *Plague of Doves* braids together the stories of multiple narrators to tell the story of a community haunted by its racist history. Fundamentally about the very real harms inflicted the Canadian residential school system inflicted on Indigenous people, *Five Little Indians* joins an impressive list of novels, memoirs, and children’s books penned by Indigenous authors about the abuses perpetuated by the society and government of Canada through the school and foster care systems. While there are too many to list here, a few notable examples are Beatrice Culleton’s 1983 *In Search of April Raintree*, about two mixed-race sisters separated by the foster care system; Eden Robinson’s 2000 mystery-thriller [Monkey Beach](#), which touches on the lingering, intergenerational effects of the schools; and Bev Sellars’s 2012 memoir, *They Called Me Number One*, which describes the experiences of the author, her mother, and her grandmother at the same residential school.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** Five Little Indians
- **When Written:** 2011–2020
- **Where Written:** British Columbia, Canada
- **When Published:** 2020
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Novel, Historical Fiction
- **Setting:** Canada in the 1970s to the early 2000s
- **Climax:** Kenny dies Howie decides to testify in the lawsuit.
- **Antagonist:** Sister Mary, Brother, Father Levesque, white Canadian society
- **Point of View:** First Person and Third Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Not Who She Said She Was. When Clara secures fake IDs, Lucy’s is for “Bunny St. Marie,” in reference to American singer-songwriter and activist Buffy St. Marie, who became infamous in 2023 when her longstanding claims of Indigenous heritage

were thoroughly debunked. The fakeness of the ID hints at St. Marie's harmful deception. But Clara's love for the singer (whose music she listens to elsewhere in the book) also testifies to the key role St. Marie played for many Indigenous activists—including Michelle Good—in the 1960s and 1970s, something Good has written about publicly elsewhere.

Ahead of His Time. Clara introduces Kendra to Mariah as “the First Indian Doctor in Canada,” but that title is thought to belong to Peter Edmund Jones (Kahkewaquonaby), who graduated from the Toronto School of Medicine in 1866.



PLOT SUMMARY

In the late 1950s and early 1960s, priests and Royal Canadian Mounted Police officers take Clara, Maisie, Kenny, Howie, Lucy, Wilfred, and Edna from their families and send them to the Mission School at Arrowhead Bay. There, Sister Mary, Brother, Father Levesque, and others subject them to psychological, emotional, mental, physical, and sexual abuse. During one session, Brother beats Howie so severely he requires hospitalization. After he recovers and returns to the school, Kenny helps him escape. Howie and his mother Sagastis flee to the United States. Soon afterward, Kenny also escapes. But when he returns to his village, he finds that his mother Bella has fallen victim to alcoholism and despair. Unable to help either her or himself find redemption, Kenny soon leaves home.

A few years later, on her 16th birthday, Lucy is discharged from the school. Sister Mary gives her \$25 and bus fare to Vancouver. In the city, a pimp named Walt tricks her into going home with him, but she quickly escapes and finds her friend Maisie. Maisie turned 16 and left the school a year earlier, and although she was sent home, she no longer felt like she fit in there, so she came to the city to make her own way in life. She has a nice boyfriend named Jimmy but works at a seedy motel called the Manitou and can't escape the demons of her past abuse at the hands of Father Levesque. Soon after Lucy arrives, Maisie takes her own life.

Two years later, after a chance meeting with her brother, Wilfred, Kenny goes to Vancouver to find Lucy. She's still working at the Manitou, where she's befriended Clara, another former inmate of Arrowhead Bay. But she's also taking night classes to finish her high school equivalent and plans to go to nursing school afterward. They're happy to have reunited, but Kenny still feels compelled to leave almost immediately. When he does, Lucy is pregnant with his child, although neither of them knows it yet.

Because she's unmarried, the nursing program kicks Lucy out when her pregnancy becomes apparent. She moves in with Clara, and after Kendra is born, they start renting a little house on Francis Street. Around this time, Clara meets George and

Vera. She becomes involved in their American Indian Movement activism, traveling south to the United States to help them with a covert operation. She is seriously injured in the process and barely escapes back over the border, where friends of George and Vera take her to Mariah, a Cree healer who lives in an isolated cabin. Mariah helps Clara to reconnect with her Indigenous heritage and to begin to work through the anger and guilt she's carried since her friend Lily's death at the residential school. When she returns to Vancouver, she decides to become a Native Courtworker so that she can advocate for other victims of the residential schools.

After escaping the school, Howie and his mother live in America for many years. When he had to return to Canada—and the school—for paperwork, he beat Brother nearly to death, earning himself a lengthy prison sentence. His mother dies before he's released. Afterward, he tries to make a new life in Vancouver. But in a moment of crisis, he steals a crucifix from a Catholic cathedral and tries to pawn it. He meets Clara after his arrest, when she is assigned as his Native Courtworker advocate.

Kenny visits Lucy and Kendra as often as he can bring himself too, but he never manages to stay for long, even after he and Lucy get married. Lucy understands and forgives him, but Kendra resents her father's ongoing abandonment. By the time she's in her early 20s, she barely wants anything to do with him. On one visit around then, Kenny learns about the lawsuit survivors of the residential schools are bringing against the government. At an informational meeting, he reunites with Howie. Kenny decides to join the lawsuit, but telling his story to the lawyer retraumatizes him. Afterward, he drinks himself into a stupor and dies in the night. From the threshold of the afterlife, he watches his family and friends conduct his funeral. He follows his mother's spirit into death, where she promises he will find peace. After his death, Lucy learns that she is the beneficiary of his \$300,000 life insurance policy. She uses the money to buy a nice house for Kendra.

Over subsequent months, Howie goes to Saskatchewan, where he grew up, to rehabilitate his childhood home. He and Clara stay in touch by mail, and their feelings for each other intensify. Eventually, he decides to testify in the victims' lawsuit, for himself and for those, like Kenny, who can no longer speak for themselves. Clara goes with him as a support person on the day of his testimony. Then, she returns to Mariah's cabin, where she finally finds peace in her soul about Lily's death. She decides to move to Saskatchewan to make a life with Howie.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Clara Woods – Clara Woods grew up on an Indian reserve with her mother. At the age of six, the authorities take her to the

Arrowhead Bay Mission School, where she befriends Lily. Clara is deeply traumatized not only by Sister Mary's emotional and psychological abuse, but from watching Lily die in front of her. After she ages out, she makes her way to Vancouver, where Harlan hires her to clean the Manitou Hotel with Liz. Clara harbors deep feelings of anger and shame from her time at the school which manifest both random violence and fierce protectiveness of her friends. This passion drives her into some dangerous operations with the American Indian Movement in the United States. After a close brush with death and arrest, Clara finds herself in the care of spiritual healer Mariah, who helps her reconnect with her Indigenous roots. Clara is a fierce and loyal friend to Lucy. She becomes a second mother to Kendra, and she repeatedly admonishes Kenny for his inability to stay with his wife and daughter. Eventually, she becomes a Native Courtworker to advocate for Indigenous people. She's assigned to Howie after his second arrest, and she encourages him and Kenny to testify as victims of the residential school system. As her feelings for Howie grow, she realizes how much guilt and shame she still carries from Lily's death, so she seeks Mariah's counsel and eventually finds a hard-earned sense of peace and redemption. Finally ready to move on with her life, she plans to settle down in Saskatchewan with Howie.

Howie Brocket – Howie Brocket is a Cree man who grew up in Saskatchewan with his mother, Sagastis. He was kidnapped by authorities and forced to attend the Arrowhead Bay Mission School while on a visit to his Auntie Mae, who lives in British Columbia. At the school, he befriends Kenny and Wilfred. His time also overlaps with Clara's (briefly), Maisie's, Edna's, and Lucy's. He suffers from Sister Mary's psychological and emotional abuse and Brother's physical and sexual abuse. On one nighttime visit, Brother injures Howie so severely that he must be hospitalized. During this time, his family hatches a plan to rescue him, after which he and his mother flee to America. Many years later, having returned to Canada and run into Brother, Howie earns a prison sentence for nearly beating Brother to death. When he's paroled, he makes his way to Vancouver. There, Connie and Mike help him get back on his feet. After Kenny has a second run-in with the law, Clara helps him get his life on track. Before long, he decides to return to Saskatchewan, fix up his mother's place, and make a new life for himself. When Kenny dies prematurely, Howie decides to testify in the residential school victims' case against the Canadian government. And afterward, following several years of deepening romantic feelings, he asks Clara to live with him.

Lucy – Lucy attends the Arrowhead Bay Mission School along with her brother, Wilfred, Howie, Clara, Maisie, and Edna. It's there that she first finds herself drawn to Kenny as a kindred spirit. Like the other children, she endures physical, emotional, and sexual abuse from Sister Mary and Father Levesque. By the time she ages out at 16, she's developed obsessive and compulsive habits. Sister Mary sends her to Vancouver, where

she is immediately picked up by a pimp named Walt. Luckily, she escapes and finds Maisie, who helps her begin to navigate life on the outside. After Maisie's death, Lucy earns her high school equivalent and enrolls in nursing school. Her plans are derailed somewhat when she becomes pregnant with Kendra, but she eventually finishes her program and becomes a nurse. She and Clara become close, forming their own untraditional family to raise Kendra. Even though Kenny marries Lucy, he can never find enough stability to stay with her and Kendra for long. Despite his ongoing abandonment, Lucy understands and always forgives Kenny. She works hard to give Kendra a better life than she had, and she succeeds.

Kenny – Kenny attended the Arrowhead Bay Mission School along with Howie, Wilfred, Clara, Lucy, and Edna. Unable to endure Sister Mary's emotional abuse and Brother's sexual abuse, Kenny makes multiple, frequent escape attempts. He finally succeeds around the age of 12. With the help of Uncle Clifford and Mack, he makes it back to his mother Bella, although he soon leaves her, too, driven to wander restlessly in search of peace. Many years later, he reconnects with Lucy in Vancouver. But he can't stay with her either, even after she gives birth to their daughter, Kendra, and they get married. Despite his physical absence, Kenny works hard, sending money to his mother until her death, and to Lucy and Kendra until his death—after which they receive his \$300,000 life insurance payout. Throughout his life, the ghosts of his past—particularly Brother's sexual abuse—haunt Kenny. He decides to testify about what he suffered just before his untimely death from years of alcohol abuse.

Maisie – Maisie attended the Arrowhead Bay Mission School along with Kenny, Howie, Wilfred, Clara, Edna, and Lucy. Like the rest, she was taken from her parents when she turned six, and she endured miserable conditions, Sister Mary's physical and emotional abuse, and Father Levesque's sexual abuse for ten long years. After she aged out, she went home but discovered that she could not reconnect with her parents, whom she distrusted for failing to protect her. She leaves to make a life for herself in Vancouver, where she gets a job cleaning the Manitou for Harlan and finds a boyfriend, Jimmy. But she's haunted by her residential school experiences, driven to reenact Father Levesque's abuse with the Old Man. When Jimmy discovers her double life, she can no longer endure the shame or her hopeless sense that she will never be able to escape her trauma. With Steve's drugs, she takes her life by deliberately overdosing.

Mariah – Mariah is an elderly Cree woman who lives in an isolated cabin in the wilderness of Saskatchewan. Her grandmother raised her there after her mother's death of tuberculosis when she was small. Mariah and her grandmother represent the traditional culture and lessons that Indigenous people passed down to their children. It was this chain of culture which the residential schools sought, in part, to destroy.

Mariah hunts, traps, forages, and grows most of her food. Friends like George and Vera, who visit Mariah's sweat lodge, provide the few things Mariah can't make on her own. Mariah is a skilled physical and emotional healer, and in time she helps Clara to move on from some of the grief and guilt she suffers.

George – George is an Indigenous man who is involved with the American Indian Movement. He and his wife Vera befriend Clara and others via the Indian Friendship Center. They help Clara, Lucy, and Kendra move into their new home, and they help Clara find her way to Mariah. Unlike the other Indigenous men depicted in the novel, George is proud, happy, and comfortable in his own skin. He doesn't let white people intimidate him. He thus represents the kind of person Kenny, Howie, and others should and would be, if the residential school systems and broader social prejudices hadn't destroyed their heritage, identities, and psyches.

Vera – Vera is George's wife and Clara's friend. She's also a spiritual daughter of Mariah, and it's through her work that Clara finds her way to Mariah's cabin. Along with George, Vera represents the kind of life that Lucy, Clara, Maisie, and others should have been able to have—happy, stable, grounded—but were denied by the abuse they suffered in the residential school system.

Sagastis – Sagastis is Howie's mother. She has a close relationship with her sister, Auntie Mae, and it's on a visit to Mae that she loses Howie to the Arrowhead Bay Mission School. Instead of returning to Saskatchewan, she stays in British Columbia and tries to advocate for his return until she, Mae, and Charlie finally rescue Howie. Subsequently, she takes him to the United States. When Howie ends up in prison, Sagastis returns to her home in Saskatchewan, where she dies of a heart attack several years before Howie's release.

Bella – Bella is Kenny's mother. After the authorities take Kenny away to the mission school, she tries her hardest to get him back, stopping only when Father Levesque threatens to have her arrested. After this, she succumbs to depression and despair and becomes an alcoholic. Although she tries to change her ways when Kenny comes home, too much of her spirit has already died, and she's unable to fully stop drinking or be fully present as Kenny's mother.

Jimmy – Jimmy is Maisie's boyfriend. His parents saved him from the residential schools by fleeing to the United States when he was young. As a result, he neither understands nor fully accepts what happened to Maisie or Lucy. In the novel, he is the voice of insensitivity and doubt, representing people who either disbelieve survivors' accounts or want to know why they can't move on from what happened to them as children.

Mack – Mack is a fisherman and friend of Clifford Bart's. By chance, he discovers Kenny when Kenny flees the mission school, but he takes pity on the boy and shelters him rather than turning him into the authorities. When Kenny decides to

leave home as a teenager, Mack gives him a job on his fishing boat.

Sister Mary – Sister Mary is a nun who works at the Arrowhead Bay Mission School. She subjects the children in her care to abuse and humiliation, including shaving the girls' heads as punishment. She doesn't believe Lucy when Lucy tells her about Father Levesque's sexual abuse and punishes the girl as a liar instead.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Wilfred – Wilfred is Lucy's brother and Kenny's and Howie's friend during their time at the residential school. After he ages out at 16, Wilfred drifts around. He travels to the United States he happens to run into Kenny when they're both seasonal workers in the same apple orchard.

Lily – Lily attended Arrowhead Bay Mission School at the same time as Clara; the two were best friends. Lily died in the mission school as a child of tuberculosis. Many years later, Clara was able to obtain her remains from the Catholic Church and bury them near Mariah's cabin.

Kendra – Kendra is the daughter of Lucy and Kenny. She's raised by her mother and Clara, to whom she is deeply attached, but she grows to resent her absentee father. Eventually, she becomes a doctor.

Harlan – Harlan is the white proprietor of the Manitou Hotel. He employs Clara, Maisie, Liz, and Lucy. He treats them poorly, subjecting them to racist attacks and verbal abuse as well as trying to take advantage of Lucy and making several attempts to sexually assault Clara.

Connie – Connie is a kind waitress who befriends Howie soon after he gets out of jail and who helps him get a job with Mike. Like Jimmy, Connie's parents protected her from the residential school system; her father gave up his Indigenous status to keep her safe.

Father Levesque – Father Levesque is the principal of the Arrowhead Bay Mission School. He sexually abuses girls there, including Maisie and Lucy. He refuses to let Bella have contact with her son Kenny and threatens to have her arrested if she keeps trying.

Brother – Brother is a monk who works at the Arrowhead Bay Mission School. He physically and sexually abuses boys there, including Kenny and Howie.

Clifford Bart – Clifford is Kenny's uncle. After Kenny flees from Arrowhead Bay, Clifford takes him back to their village to be reunited with Kenny's mother.

Auntie Mae – Auntie Mae is Sagastis's sister and Howie's aunt. She married a white man, Charlie, and followed him from Saskatchewan to British Columbia. She and Charlie help Sagastis rescue Howie from the school.

Uncle Charlie – Uncle Charlie is Howie’s uncle, Mae’s husband, and Sagastis’s brother-in-law. He is a white man who works in the logging camps. He helps rescue Howie from the mission school.

Maggie – Maggie was Sagastis’s neighbor until her death. When Howie moves back to his mother’s home and begins fixing it up, she becomes his friend and a kind of surrogate mother.

Edna – Edna is one of Lucy’s closest friends at Arrowhead Bay Mission School. She is one year younger than Lucy, and she makes sure that the girls celebrate together before Lucy leaves the school.

Foreman – The foreman runs the Washington state orchard where Kenny and Wilfred pick apples. He displays a prejudiced, offensive attitude toward Kenny and other Indigenous workers, and he enjoys wielding his power over them.

The Old Man – The Old Man is a man who pays Maisie to have sex with him and who plays a role in her obsessive reenactment of the abuse she suffered at the hands of Father Levesque.

Mike – Mike is the owner and proprietor of the Balmoral beer hall. He gives Howie his first job out of prison.

Old Indigenous Woman – The Old Indigenous Woman is a spectral figure whom Clara sees while she’s detoxing in a Vancouver drunk tank one night.

Walt – Walt is a pimp who tries to victimize Lucy after she arrives in Vancouver.

Steve – Steve is a drug dealer who supplies first the Old Man and then Maisie.

Rose – Rose is the senior Native Courtworker who mentors Clara.

Liz – Liz works for Harlan at the Manitou Hotel along with Maisie, Clara, and Lucy.

school system. In addition to the abuse they suffered at the school, each of the main characters suffers great hardships in the years that follow their release from the school. Kenny and Maisie face the challenge of returning home to find their families just as traumatized and changed as themselves. Howie serves prison time. Clara bears a heavy burden of guilt and rage over the death of her childhood friend Lily at the school. And Lucy must navigate the systemic racism of the welfare system as a single mother. Yet, through it all, each of them keeps fighting to make a better life for themselves and the people they care about.

Some of their stories end tragically—both Maisie and Kenny die early, preventable deaths. But even so, they both had the grit to survive the residential school system and the resilience to figure out how to fend for themselves—no matter how briefly—after they left it. And the others each find redemption and even happiness. Lucy and Kenny give their daughter Kendra the chance for a better life. Clara reconnects with Indigenous culture, becomes a Courtworker advocating for Indigenous people, and eventually finds forgiveness for Lily’s death. And Howie finally returns to the home he left when he was five. And all of them find beauty and strength in their relationships with one another and a broader community, including George, Vera, and Mariah. The main characters’ stories thus testify to the resilience of the human spirit and celebrate the legacies of each one of the hundreds of thousands of Indigenous children who also survived the Canadian residential school system.



CRUELTY AND TRAUMA

The victims of Canadian residential schools experienced severe cruelty and abuse while in the system, and *Five Little Indians* draws attention to and dramatizes this history. Illnesses, like the tuberculosis which the book implies killed Lily, were widespread. As Kenny and Howie’s need to forage for edible plants to keep from starving makes clear, malnutrition was common. Sister Mary metes out vindictive punishments, draping bedwetters in their urine-soaked sheets and shaving the heads of disobedient girls. When Kenny is caught in an escape attempt, the school staff dress him up like a girl to humiliate him. Most devastatingly, many children became victims of sexual abuse. Father Levesque rapes Maisie and Lucy, while Brother victimizes Howie and Kenny. Those who escape or survive until they’re discharged from the system at 16 bear the marks of these cruelties for the rest of their lives.

The abuse of the residential school system, as explored in the book, is intergenerational and systemic. Kenny’s mother Bella succumbs to despair and alcoholism after he is taken. Maisie can no longer trust her parents after she gets home. Both Maisie and Kenny feel compelled to endlessly repeat harmful patterns of behavior they learned at school—Kenny repeatedly



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don’t have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



RESILIENCE AND REDEMPTION

Clara, Howie, Kenny, Maisie, and Lucy were all taken from their families at the young age of six and sent to residential schools for Indigenous children in Canada. There, they endured years of suffering and abuse. *Five Little Indians* follows their attempts to navigate the world afterward, and their examples eloquently testify to the resilience of those who survived the Canadian residential

runs away, while Maisie reenacts the sexual abuse she suffered—until they die. Lucy observes that she doesn't feel like she "survived" the school even though she left it, and Clara feels like a part of her died with Lily. By highlighting the enduring effects of these childhood traumas, the book points toward the scale and scope of the problem. It also bears witness to victims' inescapable suffering, demonstrating the insufficiency of acknowledgements, apologies, and even financial compensation (like Howie receives) to make up for such lifelong suffering.



FAMILY

Whether or not their parents are still living, the inhumane practices of the government and church render all the children in *Five Little Indians* little better than orphans. The government and church steal them from their families when they are small, then actively frustrate the attempts of parents like Bella and Sagastis to get them back. They split up siblings like Lucy and Wilfred. After ten years or so in the system, these broken bonds often cannot be repaired. Kenny barely recognizes his mother, who in turn never gets over her grief. Maisie can no longer trust her parents, whom she loves but blames for failing to protect her from the abuses she endured at the residential school. Howie and his mother escape to the United States but are separated again when Howie ends up in prison and Sagastis dies before he is released.

Still, the book shows how close, supportive relationships like those a family can provide are essential to human survival and flourishing. The emotionally intense relationships the children form in the schools (Kenny and Howie, Lucy and Edna, Clara and Lily) help them survive. And although they aren't usually successful in the traditional, heteronormative way, the characters in the book do find ways to make up families for themselves. Clara and Vera find an adoptive mother in Mariah. Clara and Lucy raise Kendra as a team. And Howie adopts his mother's neighbor Maggie as a surrogate. Thus, while it bears witness to the irreparable harm the residential school system inflicted on Indigenous families, the book also demonstrates the importance of family and celebrates the resilience of its Indigenous characters as they figure out how to make families of their own against all odds.



FINDING HOME

A stable sense of home is yet another thing that the residential school system denied its victims. In *Five Little Indians*, the mission school isn't a comfortable or sheltering place at all. But neither is home, once a child has been taken: back in his village, Kenny finds dilapidated houses and abandoned parks instead of the vibrant community he remembers. Howie must ask for directions to his childhood home because he recognizes nothing when he returns after decades of absence. Mariah, in contrast, is lucky—and wise—in

part because she has a deep connection to one place: she still lives in the little cabin where her grandmother raised her. Although the book dramatizes the truism that it's impossible to go back home, it does offer hope. Although a person can't always go back, the book suggests, they have the power to make a new home for themselves where they are.

Although Lucy leaves the mission school with little more than a handmade purse, soon after Kendra is born a few years later, she begins establishing herself in the house on Francis Street. The time and energy she—and Clara, George, Vera, and Kenny—invest into cleaning, fixing it up, and planting **flowers** are what make it into a home full of love and good memories. That's why Clara and Kenny both unfailingly return to it time and again—and why Lucy can't leave even when she can get a nicer house. Likewise, Howie spends the book's final chapters transforming Sagastis's house into a place for him and Clara to share their lives. These moments show not just how important a home is to human flourishing, but how a home can be found—or made—almost anywhere there is love and sharing.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



BIRCH TREE

The birch tree represents Clara's connection to her home and to the Indigenous culture that was stolen from her when she was taken from her family and placed in the residential school. Birch trees were an important resource for many Indigenous nations: their bark can be used to make canoes, paper, and even clothing. In addition, the leaves and bark both have medicinal uses. Clara's transformational journey of redemption begins when the Old Indigenous Woman draws her attention to a birch tree situated outside a Vancouver jailhouse window. This tree in turn reminds Clara of the birch grove where, as a child, she heard the voices of spirits or angels. Her yearning to recapture that feeling leads her, through George and Vera, to Mariah's cabin, where she finds a sense of home for the first time in many years.



FLOWERS

The flowers that grow in Lucy's back yard on Francis Street, in Sagastis's garden in Saskatchewan and elsewhere in *Five Little Indians* represent the resilience and strength of the book's Indigenous characters. Although they sign the lease after the bloom has passed, it's the thought of the blossoms on the ornamental cherry trees out front that convinces Lucy she'll be able to make a home for Kendra there. And she makes the place her home base—and

Kendra's, and Clara's, and Kenny's—in part through cultivating ornamental plants in the back yard. When Howie plants tiger lilies on his mother's grave, this act marks his return to her after many years away and shows how he's redeemed some of the suffering both he and she went through by surviving.

resilience—traits that the residential school tried and failed to deprive him of.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Harper Perennial edition of *Five Little Indians* published in 2020.

Chapter 1: Kenny Quotes

☞ With less than a hundred yards behind him, Kenny ran back, untied the punt and pushed it back into the water. Let them think I drowned. Once again, he reached the crest of the hill. Not far off, the main road, a grey-black ribbon, wound toward the harbour. He thought of that cop who didn't believe him, and rather than risk capture again, he walked along the craggy shoreline. Just as the last light of dusk seeped into the darkening sea, he stepped onto the docks and made his way to the far end, away from junctures, searching out areas where the fewest people might be. The throaty call of the owls warming up for the nightly hunt got him thinking about bears and coyotes hungry for the day's remains from the boats, and he wandered back in the direction he'd come from, craving some sort of shelter.

Related Characters: Howie Brocket, Kenny, Clifford Bart

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 9

Explanation and Analysis

Having escaped the residential school in the wake of Howie's severe beating, Kenny makes it as far as Port McNeill, where he hopes he can find his Uncle Clifford. Kenny is only about 12 years old, and this passage highlights his vulnerability and isolation. No one knows he's here, and so if a bear or a coyote does find him and decide to attack him, not only will no one rescue him, but most likely, no one will ever know what has happened to him.

But the natural predators are a fitting presence in this dark and gloomy scene, because Kenny has already faced far more dangerous, human predators at the school. He's had to handle and try to protect himself since he was six years old, and he's learned many skills along the way. Although in this moment he's deeply traumatized and deeply alone, he's not beaten. His escape shows his determination and

☞ They fell into an easy routine, tending the smokehouse, carefully preserving the half-smoked salmon, managing a simple life. On Sundays, they would stay home all day with the curtains closed, just in case the visiting priest got wind of Kenny's return. Neither of them spoke of their years apart, and over time the truth of their separation grew between them, like a silent wound, untended and festering. Kenny started spending more time at the docks, visiting the fishermen and making friends [...], Bella started spending less time at the smokehouse and more time at the kitchen table, smoking and gazing out the window. Sometimes she wouldn't even hear Kenny when he came in from a day of wandering. He would slip into the chair beside her and marvel at the two-inch ash at the end of her smoke.

Related Characters: Kenny, Bella, Clifford Bart

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 23

Explanation and Analysis

After escaping the school, Kenny does the impossible and makes it home to his mother. But by the time he gets home, they've spent about as much time apart as they were together in his life: he was taken when he was six, and now he's around 12 years old or so. And while neither Kenny nor Bella accepted his incarceration in the mission school without a fight—Kenny made multiple escape attempts, and Bella wrote letters and harassed government and school officials until they threatened to arrest her—their relationship proves to be in, in some ineffable but inescapable ways, beyond repair.

Bella's tragic inability to escape the despair and alcoholism into which she fell after her husband's death and Kenny's departure for the residential school points to the ways in which the residential school system didn't just harm the children who were forced into the schools: it also victimized whole families and communities. Although Clifford and Bella's quick-thinking father was able to keep them out of the schools, Bella still got caught up in—and was harmed by—the system through Kenny. The system was designed to break up familial bonds and to assimilate children through ruining their connection with their culture. This passage explores some of the ways in which that worked, and further traumatized the children's parents, too.

Chapter 2: Lucy Quotes

☛☛ Lucy counted, a habit she never slipped out of since that first day in the classroom when Sister had hit her over and over with her pointer stick because she didn't know her letters. Now she counted everything, especially when she was nervous, which seemed to be more and more often. She counted the cots in the dorm, the desks in the classroom, the tables in the dining hall, the panes in the windows, the seconds it took for the clouds to cover the moon. It calmed her. Tonight, she counted the seconds it took for Edna to return to the dorm, one thousand, two thousand, three thousand, four. It was as if Edna wouldn't come back if she didn't count. Five thousand, six thousand, seven thousand. Finally, she returned, looking like a wiry hobo with her pillowcase slung over her shoulder, bulging with the promise of a good feed.

Related Characters: Lucy, Wilfred, Sister Mary, Edna

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 31

Explanation and Analysis

On the night before she leaves the Mission School, Edna decides to throw a going-away party—complete with stolen pastries from the school kitchen—for her friend Lucy. This passage describes how Lucy lies in the dark dormitory and counts the seconds as they pass. It also reveals that she counts all sorts of other things in her daily life. Counting, this passage makes clear, is Lucy's most powerful response to the trauma she suffered at the school. Throughout the rest of her life, she will count things, rearrange items in her cupboards, and engage in other obsessive rituals that seem designed to give her a sense of control and a reason to believe that there's order in the world.

But this passage also connects the counting habit with the fear that lies behind it. Lucy feels like she must count to ensure Edna's return. Like every other child in the school, the authorities took Lucy from her family and her community when she was young. Although she and her brother Wilfred attend the same school, they're never even allowed to talk to each other. This creates in her—and the others—a powerful, often overwhelming sense of abandonment. It's important for readers to remember this foundational wound, which drives the characters in this book to create families for themselves—and in many cases, prevents them from forming or sustaining those important, supportive bonds.

Chapter 3: Maisie Quotes

☛☛ [Dad] smelled of woodsmoke and fish, and that primal smell tumbled me back in time to a thin memory of me and my mom meeting him at the dock, him tossing me in the air, me laughing so hard my belly hurt. He would carry me home like I weighed nothing, my face in the crook of his neck, rough sea salt rubbing off on my face. They told me that after I was taken, no one told them where I was. They still didn't know which school I'd been sent to. I couldn't help but wonder if they'd tried to find out. They must have. But the angry question kept rising in my anyway, and their constant affection began to disgust me. I lasted a month. No matter how hard I tried, [...] these people, though kind and loving, were like strangers pretending to be family.

Related Characters: Maisie (speaker), Kenny, Bella

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 59

Explanation and Analysis

In an extended flashback, Maisie talks about leaving the Arrowhead Bay Mission School and returning home to her parents—whom she hasn't seen in 10 years. Her experience both mirrors and differs from Kenny's. In contrast to Bella, Maisie's parents haven't changed much. But in a way, this is just as hurtful—if not more so—to Maisie. It makes her feel as if her absence didn't affect them. This in turn makes it hard to believe their assurances that they missed her, suffered for her loss, and tried to find her and get her back. She's so traumatized that she can't trust them even when they assure her that they did everything they could to help bring her home.

The fact that so little about her parents has changed also magnifies how much Maisie has changed. Maisie's parents are so unchanged that hugging her father brings back a flood of visceral memories from her childhood. But the little girl full of belly laughs at her father's games is gone, destroyed by the cruelty and abuse Maisie suffered at the school.

●● Not so long ago I was at the Balmoral and met a girl from up there. After the expected ritual of who your aunts and uncles are, she told me she was sorry about my mom. I didn't know, but she didn't need to say more. I had so many dreams at the Indian School about going home to her. Dreams about sleeping safe in my own room, playing on the beach at ease and without fear, and cooking with her. What I so desperately needed was to be standing on that stool by the stove, carefully stirring under her watchful eye like when I was little. To be little again, living without fear and brutality—no one gets that back. All that's left is a craving, insatiable empty place.

Related Characters: Maisie (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 59-60

Explanation and Analysis

Maisie confides in readers that she only found out about her mother's death by chance and that she wasn't as upset about it as she might have been—although later, she's heartbroken when she loses the only picture she has of her mother, which suggests that the death affected her more than she's willing to admit. In this passage, she reflects more on what the residential school truly cost her: not just the 10 years she was there, but also her childhood and the whole other life she might have had.

Maisie has just finished describing her inability to reconnect with her family and her home after she got out of the school. So much had changed in her that she no longer felt like she fit or belonged in her home or her family. The school stole an innocence that could not be replaced. Maisie's dreams aren't just about going back home: they're about traveling back in time to a moment before she'd been victimized and abused by the system. And she still longs for that—at the end of the passage, she moves seamlessly from describing her dreams at the residential school to talking about her longing in the present tense. She still longs to go back to a moment from which she could grow up into the person she was meant to be rather than the traumatized and haunted victim she is now. Her experience shows that some of the things the residential school system took from its victims cannot be replaced or repaid.

●● I left Lucy alone again that night. [...] I grabbed my special bag and headed for the Kingsway bus, ready for the transformation again. When I first got out of the Mission, I only had to go out maybe once a month, sometimes once every two months even, and I would be fine. That unbearable panic and urge to scream that I could barely suppress would ease. But now, it seemed like every day all day, it was all I could think of. The last few months the Old Man had given me something to smoke. Called it horse. Said I'd like it, and I did. Made it hard to remember and easy to forget the disgust I felt for him, for myself, for my need to do it again and again, like it might make it all go away.

Related Characters: Maisie (speaker), Clara Woods, Lucy, Jimmy, Father Levesque, The Old Man

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 70

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Maisie describes the compulsion that sends her back to the Old Man time and again and shows how her reaction to the trauma of her sexual abuse leads her into drug use. Of all the victims portrayed in *Five Little Indians*, Maisie engages in the most direct and ongoing self-destructive behavior. But by allowing her to tell her story in her own words and giving her the chance to explain—however imperfectly—what drives her into sex with the Old Man, drug use, and self-harming behavior like cutting, Maisie asks for readers' empathy rather than their judgment.

Maisie's story asks readers to look beyond the actions to the trauma that lies at their root and to take stock before revictimizing her—or others like her—by blaming them for actions they cannot fully control. Instead of behaving like the police officers who throw Maisie or Clara in jail for their disorderly actions, this passage asks readers to see what lies behind those actions. All of Maisie's actions aim to soothe her suffering. They fail to do so because they don't address its root causes—and their failure reflects back the failure of society first to protect Maisie and people like her and then to help them when the degree of their suffering becomes clear.

Chapter 5: Lucy Quotes

☛ Not long after her arrival in Vancouver, Lucy quit her evening routine of rolling the giant pink curlers in her hair and securing them against her scalp with the bobby pins she had brought with her from the Mission School. She was mesmerized by the hippie girls who sometimes wandered away from Fourth Avenue into the downtown core. She saw their white-pink lipstick, dramatic kohl eyes and long, straight, hair, shiny and swaying, unhindered by the brittle freeze of hairspray. In the years since Lucy's departure from the Mission, her hair had grown past her shoulder blades. She thought it grew faster now that it was free of Sister's temper and her well-used razor [...]. She watched the hippie girls living with a freedom that came naturally without anything or anyone to fear or resist. She wondered if they could even imagine a life without such abandon.

Related Characters: Lucy, Maisie, Sister Mary

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 95-96

Explanation and Analysis

Two years after Maisie's death, Lucy is still living in Vancouver, and although her life is challenging, she's figuring out how to navigate it successfully. In this passage, she muses on one of the habits she's lost since she left the residential school: styling her hair the way Sister Mary and the others required. At school, she would style and hairspray her hair so that it didn't look like "Indian hair," but wasn't stylish either. Changing styles—and forcing students to conform to white standards of beauty—was yet another way of denying the students their Indigenous identities and their individuality, since no one had a choice in the matter. Now that Lucy has a choice, she exercises it. Notably, too, the hairstyle that was deemed too subversive in the school is actually quite popular among a certain subset of white culture—the hippies. This seems to suggest that different rules apply to white and Indigenous people.

Lucy's hair is but one example of the way the residential schools denied Lucy—and others like her—freedom and autonomy throughout their childhoods. And even now that she's free of Sister's control, the fact that her memories of that time lie so close to the surface, and that they come back to her so frequently, shows that may never be free of them. Every free choice she makes now reminds her of the constraints she lived under in the past.

☛ Lucy left the lights off and quietly sat at the kitchen table. She watched the usual goings-on outside her window but remained distracted and overwhelmed by the flood of memories she'd worked so hard to keep below the surface. Clara had been there with her at the Mission School, but she was older and they hadn't talked about it much. It was an unspoken agreement between them: the past was the past. It's hard to run from the past, but once stuffed away, they knew it couldn't be allowed to poison the present moment. They couldn't be who they were now, with their lipstick, paycheques and rooms, if they were also those children, or the children who'd left the other children behind.

Related Characters: Clara Woods, Lucy, Kenny

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 101

Explanation and Analysis

The day Lucy passes her final high school equivalency class is also the day that Kenny unexpectedly walks back into her life. She's both happy and distressed to see him again, for reasons she explains in this passage—reasons that mirror Kenny's complicated feelings in an earlier chapter when he was unexpectedly reunited with Wilfred. The relationships that the children formed at the residential school were key to their survival in that harsh and horrible place; Lucy treasures her memories of Kenny as one of the few beautiful and inspiring things she can hold onto from her earlier years.

Yet, the pleasure of their connection cannot be separated from the horrific circumstances in which it happened. This is why Lucy and the others so often express the sentiment that while they left the schools physically, they don't feel like they survived or walked away mentally. And it's why Kenny struggles to build a family or community for himself after he escapes. Without opportunities to process and heal from childhood trauma, this passage claims that such trauma will always lie uncomfortably close to the surface, threatening to break through a carefully constructed adult life at the slightest provocation. Lucy says so directly: the best she's able to do on her own is to try to force it from her mind for as much of the time as possible. This is an awful price to pay, and the book asks readers to acknowledge and reckon with it.

Chapter 6: Clara Quotes

☛☛ Lily's pale little face seemed to hover in the air in front of Clara, soaking and shivering on that bench, and once again the rage rose up in her. She leapt from the bench and ran across the parking lot, the rock raised high above her head. With a scream, she threw the rock through the lobby window of the Manitou, and then raced away into the night. She could hear the wailing of the alarm bell as she ran.

Related Characters: Clara Woods, Lucy, Maisie, Lily, Harlan, Sister Mary

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 115

Explanation and Analysis

This passage comes from the first chapter to focus on Clara's character. In previous Maisie and Lucy chapters, readers already got a glimpse into two key aspects of Clara's character: her occasionally explosive temper (she attacked Harlan for harassing Lucy about her classes) and her occasionally excessive alcohol consumption (she arrives at work hungover, and Maisie implies it wasn't the first time). Finally, in this chapter, readers see how these two branches grow from the root of Clara's residential school trauma, specifically the death of her friend Lily.

This passage makes it clear how Clara filters all subsequent injustices, slights, and horrors through that early experience. She sees how they are connected—the same systemic racism and dehumanization of Indigenous people underwrites both Harlan's assumption that he can take advantage of Clara and her friends and Sister Mary's refusal to treat Lily as a human being who needed—and deserved—medical care instead of punishing chores. In this light her reaction makes sense, but it doesn't help her or anyone else. Her rage is justified, but until she finds a way to channel it appropriately, this moment suggests, it will only cause chaos and destruction.

☛☛ “That little birch tree. Even here they shine.”

Clara looked again. A little birch, no taller than Clara herself, stood alone in a small square of dirt carved out of the pavement for it. The rain had stopped and the clouds parted for the muted sunlight of dawn. Clara watched as the leaves of the little tree captured the light, shining silvery and soft. The old woman looked at her with eyes as black as night and placed her hand over Clara's.

“The power of Creation is everywhere. In the tree, in you, in all of them.” She gestured to the others. “Never forget.” The old lady settled back into the variegated shadows of the cell, her deeply wrinkled hands folded. Clara gazed at the little birch, blocking out the restless sounds of the cell.

Related Characters: Old Indigenous Woman (speaker), Clara Woods, Mariah, Lily, Harlan

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 116-117

Explanation and Analysis

After Clara breaks the window of the Manitou, a police officer picks her up before she can escape to the neighborhood. He brings her to the police station to wait out the night in the drunk tank. There, Clara encounters an enigmatic old Indigenous woman, who draws her attention to a birch tree growing in view of the jail's window. Clara loves birch trees. Seeing this one instigates a flashback to her childhood that confirms the old woman's words: she did once intuitively understand the connection between herself and the spiritual world, before the residential school destroyed her faith in herself, God, and the world. This moment is a turning point in Clara's life, one that sets her on the path to healing, even if it takes her years to actually get there.

This passage also draws an explicit connection between Clara's situation and the tree's. The tree offers hope—even in the city, it's shining—but it's also limited. Instead of growing wild and tall in nature, it's consigned to a tiny box of dirt on the side of a street. This strongly suggests that its future size and strength are limited. Thus far, Clara has survived by fitting herself into the box society provides for her. She does demeaning work for under-the-table money and lives on the fringes of society without a proper education, career, or real stability. Without much of a choice, she fulfills Harlan's stereotype of the “Indian chick” fated to become a sex worker or a maid. To reach her full potential—to become a deeply rooted tree—she must go to

the wilderness where trees thrive. This moment thus foreshadows the time she will spend with Mariah in subsequent chapters.

Chapter 7: Lucy Quotes

💡 Lucy looked away. "You're gonna think I'm stupid."

Clara laughed. "I already know you're stupid, so what can it hurt?"

The two giggled, startling Baby-girl. Lucy held her closer and she quit her half-hearted fussing. Lucy looked away again and blushed. "I thought they wouldn't give her to me."

"What? You see? I knew you were stupid." They giggled again, but this time Clara stood up and put her arm around Lucy and the baby.

Lucy whispered, "Were we ever allowed anything good?"

They sat in silence together, lost in a shared truth rarely spoken.

Clara rallied first. "Let me hold her!"

Beaming, Lucy handed Baby-girl over.

The infant cooed and gurgled in Clara's arms.

Related Characters: Clara Woods, Lucy (speaker), Kenny, Wilfred, Kendra

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 121-122

Explanation and Analysis

Soon after Kendra is born, Clara visits her and Lucy in the hospital. It was a C-section birth, so hospital staff took Kendra into the nursery while Lucy recovered from anesthesia. But when Clara arrives, she learns that Lucy hasn't yet asked to see or hold her newborn. In this passage, she and Lucy discuss the reason why: Lucy didn't trust that she would be allowed to keep her child. When she confesses this fear to Clara, readers should remember some of the incidents that lie behind it. She wasn't allowed to have a friendship with Kenny or a relationship with her brother Wilfred in the residential school. She also lost her connection other parents there. And Maisie's death deprived her of one of her closest friends. Finally, she was kicked out of the nursing program when her pregnancy became apparent. In short, Lucy fears losing the good things in her life because she has so often before. And she's not wrong: on the following day, a welfare worker will suggest that the state presumes her incompetence and *will* take

Kendra away unless Lucy can prove that she is a fit mother.

Importantly, however, Lucy isn't completely right either. No matter what the schools or society have tried to take away from her, they haven't and cannot deprive her of her humanity. Her friendship with Clara is one good thing that no one can take away, and the strength of their friendship—the chosen family they make with each other—is something that they have to offer to each other and to Kendra.

💡 "What's wrong? Whaddo I do?"

"Jeez, stop rocking her so hard, you're freakin' me out." Clara dug through the basket where she'd dumped all the stuff they'd brought home from the hospital. She grabbed a little booklet with a picture of some rich white lady giving her baby a bottle. Do's and Don'ts: Feeding Your Bundle of Joy. "Here," she said, "gimme the baby. You read." Clara started rocking the baby, trying to stay calm.

Lucy flipped the pages, reciting headings: "Formula...Breast Milk...Bloating...Gas...Gas! I bet she has gas."

"Okay, genius, but what do we do about it?"

Lucy flipped another page and was visibly relieved by the illustration of a mother burping her baby. "Hand her over."

Related Characters: Clara Woods, Lucy (speaker), Kendra

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 128

Explanation and Analysis

On the first day after she brings Lucy and Kendra back to their shared apartment, Clara comes home from running errands to find a panicked Lucy trying to console a wailing Kendra. In this passage, the two women work together to figure out what the baby needs—and to provide it. Their confusion shows some of the long-term consequences of splitting up Indigenous families. Not only did the residential school system deny these children a connection with their culture and their individual families, but it also compromised their ability to perform familial roles, like taking care of babies, in the families they make for themselves.

Clara's and Lucy's cluelessness contrasts sharply with Clara's memories of her mother, which highlight her wisdom and knowledge about women's issues like birthing and caring for babies. In contrast, Lucy and Clara have to learn how to take care of Kendra from a little pamphlet, because

they were denied the opportunity to grow up in families and communities where they would have more naturally been exposed to childcare—and where they might also have had access to the wisdom and experience of their own mothers.

Chapter 8: Clara Quotes

☞ The grainy image of a group of Indians in front of a big old white church zoomed into close-up. There stood a slight brown woman, her fist in the air, microphone pressed toward her face. A detached voice rose above the chatter: “Tell us why you’re here, Mae.” She looked straight into the camera, fearless, furious, determined. “Who do these white people think they are? Our people saved their raggedy asses when they got off the boat, freezing and starved. They returned the favor with hatred and murder. There weren’t so many of them and it changed everything. There ain’t so many of us and we will change everything, too, and we will change everything, too, and I will lay my life down to take back what’s ours.” Clara was transfixed by this woman.

Related Characters: Clara Woods, Lily, Kendra

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 135

Explanation and Analysis

During the early months of Kendra’s life, Clara spends more and more time at the Friendship Center. There, she pays attention to the growing American Indian Movement. This passage describes a news broadcast she watches one day, in which an AIM activist explains why she—and others like her—are willing to fight for their rights as Indigenous people. Clara finds the woman’s example inspiring in part because activism gives her a chance to channel her rage and guilt into fighting the systems that oppressed and hurt her, Lily, and so many other people she knows.

Mae gives voice to Clara’s feelings here and articulates an important truth about the abuse that she and others suffered. It wasn’t just individual acts of cruelty at the hands of Brother or Sister Mary; it was part of white colonialism’s systemic attempt to oppress Indigenous people. Yet, Mae’s activism testifies to the resilience of the victims of these murderous systems. She’s alive and she vows to take the fight to her oppressors. Likewise, the survival of Clara and every other victim of the residential school system testifies to their individual and collective resilience. Mae’s words become an inspiration and guide for Clara as she starts to channel her rage and pain into changing her own life and the

lives of others.

This passage honors AIM activist Anna Mae Aquash, a member of the Mi’kmaq tribe who was born in Nova Scotia, Canada and murdered in 1975 at the age of 30. While questions remain about the circumstances of her death, there is consensus that it had to do with her activism. Mae’s words on the television echo sentiments Aquash expressed in a letter to her sister in the mid-1970s. Aquash was present for the 1973 Occupation of Wounded Knee, which the book implies is the event in the newscast—the large white church and the interviews with AIM activists echo the broadcast news coverage of that event.

☞ She didn’t have to call [John Lennon] this time. With the car back in order after the border pillaging, Clara walked around toward the driver’s door and that was enough for him to know. He ran to her through the purple flowering weeds, tongue lolling and happy. Weeds. She remembered George telling her once that Indians were like weeds to the white people. Something to be wiped out so their idea of a garden could grow. He told her weeds were indigenous flowers. “Clara, you’re an indigenous flower. Don’t ever think of yourself as a weed.” That’s what he said to her.

Related Characters: George (speaker), Clara Woods, Vera

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 138-139

Explanation and Analysis

As she drives south and east into the U.S., Clara ruminates on her history with George and Vera and the reasons why she’s chosen to become involved with the American Indian Movement. In this passage, she looks at the weeds and wildflowers that flourish in the roadside fields and remembers how George helped her to reframe her identity through the metaphor of flowers. In this image, white culture sees Indigenous people as weeds—inconsequential at best and annoying or harmful at worst. It then does what’s necessary to get rid of the weeds to create society in its image. This is similar to the purpose of the residential schools, which aimed to uproot Indigenous children from their culture and history and to cultivate in them the values and mores of white society.

But, as George points out, the difference between “weeds” and “flowers” is in the eye of the beholder. There’s beauty in

the wildness and freedom of native plants that cannot be tamed. He encourages Clara to stop seeing herself as a weed and start considering herself a flower. And as Clara heeds George's advice, she slowly begins to blossom into the powerful woman she truly is, leaving behind the shell-shocked and cowed victim the schools forced her to become.

Chapter 9: Howie Quotes

☞ Look, I don't want to waste your time. The only reason I am here today is because I need to hold on to my hope that I will get out of here sooner than later. I know what you need me to say. You want to know I'm sorry. That I've been rehabilitated. That I deeply regret my wrongdoing and I will never do such a thing again [...]. You already know that I have a clean record in here. Not one disciplinary note. Not a single one. And this is the only crime I ever committed, if you must call it a crime. But I am not sorry. Not at all. You have no idea what that mad did to be and a whole lotta other little boys. He deserved what he got and more. Where was the law when he was beating us, breaking bones, and other, even worse things?

Related Characters: Howie Brocket (speaker), Kenny, Brother

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 163

Explanation and Analysis

On the day of his seventh parole hearing, Howie chooses to speak directly to the parole board members weighing his case. This passage includes some of his words. Notably, he understands that the past cannot be undone, and so he neither defends his actions against Brother nor asks for an apology for what Brother did to him. Nevertheless, he indicates how the system not only failed to protect him, but actively contributed to his victimization. He wasn't necessarily right to beat Brother, but he sees his actions as a way of taking justice into his own hands after the system repeatedly failed to protect him and other victims of the schools.

This passage also illustrates Howie's sense of human dignity. He refuses to grovel before the parole board (and, by extension, readers), and he asks them to see him as a human being, a one-time victim, and to practice empathy—to imagine that if they, too, were harmed and unable to find redress in the legal systems, then they, like Howie, might have taken matters into their own hands. He also

emphasizes that the act of violence he committed doesn't indicate his character. His good behavior in jail shows the kind of man he truly is—the person he can be when he isn't pushed beyond the limits of endurance by malicious systems.

☞ I wandered up and down the six-block stretch of East Hastings, the heart of skid row, the gathering place of the unwanted. It didn't take long to figure out I wouldn't find work there. I jumped a Stanley Park bus, not sure where it would take me, and I watched the character of the neighbourhoods change from skid row, to the business core, to department stores, upscale apartment enclaves, and, finally, Burrard Inlet and the rich greenery of the park. Stepping off the bus at the park entrance, I felt as though I had been holding my breath all this time and finally, in the sanctuary of the park, I could let go and breathe easy.

Related Characters: Howie Brocket (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 172

Explanation and Analysis

After many years, Howie finally gets out of prison and boards a bus for Vancouver. But earning his freedom is only the first step in carving out a meaningful life for himself. He wants desperately to find a place for himself in the world—a home. In this passage, he rides a bus through Vancouver and the changing scenery emphatically reminds him of the place Indigenous people like him occupy in Canadian society.

Howie is supposed to stay on skid row—there's no place for him in the nicer neighborhoods. And while he can (and does) visit Stanley Park, soaking in the calm, verdant atmosphere, he can't live there and must go back to the dirty and depressing confines of the skid row neighborhood. In many ways, Howie is still imprisoned, just like he was at the school and in prison, even if the walls are less obvious. And, to add insult to injury, he knows that he won't be able to survive in the place allotted to him. In many ways, this parallels his experience in the residential schools, which segregated him and other Indigenous children out of the sight and thought of the broader White society.

●● I would have to watch my pennies and try to get by on what Mike paid me and leave what was left of my cash stash alone. I wandered back to my room, put my supplies away and, after an undisturbed shower, lay back and scanned the want ads in the newspaper. My eyes burned and I closed them, thinking a short nap wouldn't hurt after a long, wakeful night.

It was full-on dark when I woke up, gasping. I sat on the edge of the bed, letting it sink in where I was and where I wasn't. I walked to the small sink in the corner and splashed cold water on my face. The dreams had faded over the years in prison and I thought for sure, once I was free, I would be free of them too. Why were they back now, when everything was looking up?

Related Characters: Howie Brocket (speaker), Connie, Brother, Mike

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 178

Explanation and Analysis

Not long after his arrival in Vancouver, Howie secures a job at the Balmoral. It's a lucky break—but it's not enough. Having survived the residential school system and served out his prison sentence, Howie still finds himself trapped and limited by the narrow opportunities society offers to Indigenous people. Yet, he shows his determination to succeed in life outside of the prison system, and he doesn't allow his worries to bring him down—he keeps looking for opportunity, hoping that eventually he'll find the job that will help him improve his circumstances.

Howie wonders why nightmares of his trauma have come back now. Two possible answers present themselves in this passage. The first is that his lack of opportunity and financial worries leave him feeling as trapped now as he did when he was at the school or in prison. The second possible explanation is that even though Howie left the school and even escaped all the way to America, his later run-in with Brother and his subsequent prison sentence have proved to him that he cannot escape his history there. He will carry the marks of that trauma with him for the rest of his life, no matter what. And this, in turn, pointedly emphasizes the cruelty and harm that Howie and other Indigenous children experienced at the hands of the residential school systems and the society that enabled and encouraged them.

Chapter 10: Mariah Quotes

●● The sky seemed to hum with the spray of stars laid bare of clouds by the wind. Clara thought of another night sky, the full moon, small and cold, a bitter orb above the badlands as she lay there, wounded and certain her death was upon her. John Lennon had put himself between her and death, lying next to Clara against the deep chill that night. Turnaround is fair play. The near-full moon was golden and so bright it cast shadows. Still, there was something so completely unfamiliar about the earth in darkness, no matter how confident Clara walked in the daylight. Storm clouds recaptured the stars as she closed the porch door behind them.

Related Characters: Clara Woods, Lucy, Kenny, Mariah

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 185

Explanation and Analysis

After a near escape from border agents as she crossed back into Canada, a mysterious friend spirits Clara and her dog, John Lennon, away to Mariah's cabin. There, Clara comes to in confusion. When she goes outside to get John Lennon, she's overwhelmed by the vision of the stars in the clear night sky. This passage makes clear that Clara's experiences at the residential school—and later in Vancouver, where she has scraped by on the fringes of society—didn't just cut her off from the world of her family and of her culture: it also cut her off from the world itself. Clara has seen the moon before this night, but she's never experienced it as so powerful, moving, and close as it seems now, as it hangs in the sky above Mariah's cabin. The moon's friendly face promises that more revelations of beauty will come if she's willing to open herself to them.

It is also notable that she sees the stars when she goes outside to collect John Lennon. Clara's love for and devotion to her dog—and her need for his love and devotion in return—speak to the powerful human need for connection and companionship. But like Kenny, this is something Clara still struggles to trust with other people. She and Lucy have become close, but not so close that Clara can't easily leave her behind to go to the United States. The dog seems safer to her, and he's just proved that he will never abandon her when she needs him. It's huge that she's learning to trust another creature, but Clara still needs to grow and heal enough to open herself to human connections, too.

☛ Within a couple of weeks Mariah and Clara slipped into a comfortable routine. Mariah cooked and was thankful that Clara kept the woodbox full. Sometimes, on clear days, Mariah would take Clara out on her trapline [...]. Whenever they found [a rabbit] in a snare, Mariah would reach into the pouch tied around her waist, put down tobacco with soft Cree words, and then knock it over the head, efficiently and even lovingly. She taught Clara the unique way of skinning a rabbit, much like taking off a sweater [...]. Clara would get dizzy sometimes as she watched Mariah dress the rabbits, thinking back to Indian School and how Sister Mary would've knocked her on the head if she saw a return to such savagery. It pleased Clara, thinking of that evil woman and how she would see her Christian mission had failed, seeing Clara in the hands of this pagan.

Related Characters: Clara Woods, Mariah, Sister Mary

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 194

Explanation and Analysis

This passage describes comfortable routine that Clara and Mariah fall into over the winter during which Clara recuperates at Mariah's cabin. The purpose of the residential schools was to remove Indigenous children from their families and to divorce them from their cultures, and all the book's characters bear the scars of that process. Here, however, Mariah undoes much of that work, quietly teaching Clara about the ways of her ancestors. This winter is a homecoming for Clara: a return to her cultural roots. Further, Mariah's very existence, and particularly the way she's preserved traditional practices, testifies to the resilience of the human spirit and of Indigenous cultures despite vigorous efforts to stamp them out. The old ways survive, waiting to be passed on to willing learners.

Near the end of the passage, Clara thinks with glee about how horrified Sister Mary would be to see her now as she reverts to "savage" and "pagan" ways. But while Mariah may technically be a pagan (a person who practices a religion other than Christianity or Judaism), it's impossible to see her actions as savage (fierce or inhuman—but notably also a word used to describe Indigenous people and traditions by white colonizers). She traps rabbits for food and for fur, but she treats them with respect and even kindness. In contrast, Sister treated the children in her care with less respect than Mariah shows the rabbits, suggesting that Sister was the true savage all along.

Chapter 11: Kenny Quotes

☛ [O]ver the next few weeks [Kenny] happily settled into a home life he'd only ever dreamed of. It seemed easier this time. It was just a matter of days when he was home last before those restless urges were on him. It was not a lack of love, but something inside of him that drove him, something he could never explain to Lucy, much less to himself. A pressure that only eased up if he was on the move. But this time, things were going well. The foreman put him on the books after only a week, telling him what a hard worker he was. He was always on time and never showed up drunk.

Kendra seemed to grow every day [...].

They spent Kenny's days off at the beach or the neighbourhood park [...]. So it was a surprise to him when fall came and that old restless urge returned.

Related Characters: Lucy, Kenny, Kendra

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 208

Explanation and Analysis

This passage comes from a moment in Kendra's early life, during one of Kenny's periodic visits to Vancouver to visit her and Lucy. Kenny's inability to stay in one place or to participate fully in family life illustrates the lingering trauma he suffers from his time at the residential school. One of the many ways this trauma manifests is in a need to reenact the patterns learned there, and so Kenny's entire life is characterized by a strong urge to run away and to flee. And this in turn generates more trauma for Kenny, as it prevents him from developing a strong relationship with Kendra as she grows up.

This is another place where the book quietly works to address negative stereotypes about Indigenous people, pointing out how certain kinds of self-destructive or self-defeating patterns are reflections of the trauma that shaped his life, not a symptom of his innate character flaws. Taken from his home and his family when he was just six years old, it makes sense that Kenny would struggle to adapt to family life as an adult. By showing readers Kenny's struggle and by illuminating the confusion and pain that his own actions cause him, the book asks readers to practice empathy and to see the ways that systems of oppression destroy the lives of their victims in direct and indirect ways.

Chapter 12: Clara Quotes

Over the next few months, Clara bit her tongue, listened and watched. She thought of what it was like to lose your freedom. She thought of her helplessness at the Mission and being under the thumb of Harlan and the city cops. She met with court staff, judges and prosecutors during her training and hung on their every word, gleaning everything she could. It wasn't easy to say the words that all of them needed to hear, but Rose was right. This was about those people standing helpless before the law, often just trying to get by in a world they'd been abandoned to, entirely unprepared.

Related Characters: Clara Woods, Mariah, Harlan, Rose

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 223

Explanation and Analysis

Soon after she returns from her sojourn with Mariah, Clara finds her calling when she learns about the Native Courtworkers' Society. These trained advocates represent Indigenous people caught in the criminal justice system and provide counseling and other support while their clients try to get back on their feet. The training is an education for Clara in more ways than one, because it doesn't just entail learning the ins and outs of the law but also retraining herself to work the system in ways that are acceptable to white society. This passage hints at how much of the continued success and survival of Indigenous people in Canada rests on placating the culture that victimized them.

At first, this approach runs counter to Clara's justified sense of outrage and injustice. But as Rose, Clara's mentor, told her earlier, the responsibility for fostering social change rests with the politicians and the activists. It's the Native Courtworker's job to say the things that need to be said to keep their Indigenous clients out of jail—to say the kinds of things that white judges and prosecutors want to hear, and especially when victims can't say them for themselves. This becomes an important stage on Clara's path toward finding her own redemption. She still feels the outrage and anger, but now she's learning to channel it in ways that serve the vulnerable and have the possibility to make a real difference.

Later that night [...] Clara told Lucy about her first case.

The guy, not much more than a kid, had been caught stealing apples from a corner grocery. Clara leaned back in her chair. "He'd just been let out of Indian School, up north somewhere. They kept him until he was eighteen, then put him on a bus to the city."

Lucy shook her head. "Those people. What was he supposed to do? Starve?"

"Yeah, that's what I said. The judge didn't like it much, but I tried to explain he just didn't know what else to do and had nowhere to go."

"Like us. Just thrown away."

[...]

"Well, at least he's not going to jail tonight [...]. We're going to find him a job. At least he'll have one meal a day until then."

Lucy yawned, stood, planted a soft kiss on Clara's head. "Keep fighting, woman."

Related Characters: Clara Woods, Lucy, Harlan (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 225

Explanation and Analysis

After passing her Native Courtworkers' exam and beginning work, Clara tells Lucy the story of her first client. In many ways, this unnamed boy's situation isn't much different from any of the characters in the book, so his story adds more evidence attesting to the cruelty of the residential system and the ongoing trauma of trying to navigate a segregated and racist world for Indigenous people. His school keeps him for two additional years as an indentured servant—something Lucy once feared would happen to her. Like Lucy and Howie, he was then placed on a bus and sent to the city with nowhere to go and no helpful instructions or warnings. The crime he committed afterward was even pettier than Howie's crime of stealing the valuable gold crucifix. Yet even though the unnamed boy was just trying to survive, the authorities threaten him with jail time.

This moment also shows how far Clara has come from her earlier, angrier self. She still clearly feels outraged at the injustices her client (and by extension, the Indigenous community broadly speaking) has suffered, but instead of attacking individuals like Harlan or trying to directly fight systems of oppression like at Willow Flats, she works within the systems to undermine system injustice from the inside. She's still fighting, but she's turning her rage toward more productive ends, and this benefits herself and others.

Chapter 14: Kenny Quotes

☞ “I’m just going to run down to the corner. I need some more cream for the gravy.”

“You want me to go?”

“Naw. Drink your coffee. I could use the air anyway.” She slipped into her jacket, hesitating, resisting the urge to turn the lock back and forth the way she would if Kenny weren’t there, counting the clicks before opening the door. It wasn’t that Kenny didn’t know. It was just that there was nothing he could do about it, so he left her alone about it. She gave him a quick smile and opened the door.

Related Characters: Lucy, Kenny (speaker), Kendra

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 252

Explanation and Analysis

This passage relates a small moment between Kenny and Lucy during one of Kenny’s visits to her and Kendra in Vancouver. Kendra is now an adult, and when Kenny showed up earlier in the day, she angrily confronted him about his habitual abandonment, accusing him of exacerbating (if not causing) Lucy’s nervous tics like rearranging the counters, counting things, and locking and unlocking the door. But while Kendra associates her mother’s obsessive behavior solely with her father, readers know that Lucy has been counting, rearranging, and obsessing since before she left the mission school. This moment shows how Lucy remains beholden to the trauma she suffered as a little girl even now many years later. Nothing can fully erase the damage done to her.

In the larger context of the story, however, it’s also a touching indication of the love she and Kenny share. She knows that he will invariably abandon her again just as he knows that she has nervous tics. They both know that they can’t do anything about the other—and yet they remain devoted to each other regardless. This moment also sheds light on why Lucy continues to forgive Kenny for leaving her to raise their daughter alone. She forgives his brokenness because she, too, has been broken. And their love testifies to the strength of their love and the depth of their humanity.

☞ A half-hour later, Kenny stepped out of the office and headed for the men’s room. He barely made it into the stall before he puked. Why did the lawyer need to know all that? Kenny told him he was abused, but the lawyer said he needed details. More and more details. Kenny leaned over the toilet, his stomach in knots, heart pounding. He could smell Brother, leaning over him, hard against him, grabbing his hair. Kenny knew the pain in his side was his liver, but all he could think of were all those days of shallow breathing, avoiding the pain of broken ribs.

Related Characters: Kenny, Kendra, Brother

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 256

Explanation and Analysis

After learning about the lawsuit the residential school survivors are bringing against the government, Kenny adds his name to the list. Unfortunately, this requires him to explain—in excruciating detail—what he suffered at Brother’s hands all those years ago. It’s clear that his trauma still lies close to the surface. And it costs him a lot to keep the memories at bay—he’s ruined his liver with excessive drinking in an attempt to drown out his memories. And he’s lost his relationship with his daughter because he can’t spend too much time at once with other Mission School kids lest he remember too much of what happened. Even testifying for the lawyer revictimizes Kenny, forcing him to relive things he tries to avoid thinking about.

This passage thus suggests that “justice” for the victims of the residential schools is never going to be complete. Seeking it involves reopening old wounds that are often too painful to bear. And nothing can give back or replace an entire life overshadowed and dictated by trauma that should never have been allowed to happen in the first place. Thus, while acknowledgement, apologies, and financial compensation are morally necessary, they will always be insufficient.

Chapter 16: Howie Quotes

☞ He knelt and started planting the tiger lily bulbs in front of the headstone, remembering a time, when he was very little, when she would tell him the old stories about Tiger Lily and Weesageechak, and the living stories of her parents and theirs. He knew she would love having a bright-orange spray rising, year after year. The flowers reminded him of her sturdy beauty. He rose and shook the dark earth from his work gloves, picked up his tools, gave his handiwork one last look and headed for his truck.

Related Characters: Howie Brocket, Sagastis

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 271

Explanation and Analysis

Five years to the day after his mother's death, Howie and his family finally place a headstone on her grave—something the family waited to do until he returned to be there. Afterward, Howie plants flowers at the grave, and this small act testifies in a big way to the love he has for his mother and his ongoing devotion to her even though she's died. When Howie was kidnapped and taken to the Mission School, Sagastis stayed close by and never gave up on him. He was taken away from her again when he went to prison,

and he missed the final years of her life. He'll never get those back, but readers can see here that he refuses to accept that separation as permanent. Here, he comes home to Sagastis, and he intends to stay for the rest of his life.

The flowers also provide a point of connection between Howie and his ancestors—both his direct family members and the broader Indigenous community of which he is a part. The stories his mother told him connect him to his people's past. And the fact that he remembers them even after the years of attempted indoctrination and assimilation in the Mission School shows the strength and resilience of the Indigenous people and traditions even in the face of overwhelming odds. Like the flowers, they will return again and again, a testimony to all those who came before and a guiding promise for all those who come after, guiding their paths back home.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

PROLOGUE

Clara hikes on the familiar trails around Mariah's cabin. When she returns, Kendra greets her and leads her into the cabin. Mariah lights a smudge and leads the other women in prayers in the Cree language. Clara brags to Mariah that Kendra is the "[f]irst Indian doctor in Canada." And she tells Kendra that Mariah is a healer, too, a kind of soul doctor. Soon afterward, they hear a truck pull up with Lily's casket. The women and their helpers gently lower the casket into a freshly dug grave, singing honor songs as they do so. Then, Clara and Kendra follow Mariah into the sweat lodge. Clara tells Kendra to get ready for "some doctoring" as the helpers close the door.

Although it's clear that all three women are Indigenous, Kendra's lack of familiarity with the rituals Mariah and Clara know intimately suggest that something has compromised their transmission through the generations. The Prologue thus hints at the abuses of the residential school system by demonstrating its success at separating Indigenous people from their heritage. And it foregrounds the important players of Clara's chosen family—Mariah, Lily, Kendra—although it will be many chapters until readers see how all these threads come together.



CHAPTER 1: KENNY

After another one of Kenny's attempts to escape the mission school ends quickly (the engine of the punt boat he stole died leaving him adrift and the Royal Canadian Mounted Police picked him up), Brother subjects him to brutal and humiliating public punishment. One day, Lucy slips him a handwritten note that says "Yor brave."

It's clear that Kenny has tried to escape the residential school several times, even if the exact number remains a mystery. His determination to flee—as well as the punishments he receives for the attempts and the callousness of the authorities when he partially succeeds—speaks to the systemic nature of the abuse he suffered in the schools, while Lucy's admiration speaks to Kenny's importance as a human being, even if the authorities don't see it.



Kenny wakes up on the day of his next escape attempt feeling lucky. Brother didn't come for him in the night. As Sister rouses the children, she becomes frustrated with a boy named Howie who is still nestled under the covers. She grabs the mattress to roll him onto the floor, and he falls without waking up or moving. A monk hurries his bruised and bloodied body out of the dormitory as the boys whisper to each other. Brother came for Howie in the middle of the night. Kenny thinks he should be dead instead of Howie, but his friend Wilfred reminds him that none of them should have to suffer Brother's abuse.

Kenny's lucky feeling hints at how common the abuse he suffers at Brother's hand has become to him and the other boys at the school. But his good luck is Howie's bad luck. Clearly, the school is a rich hunting ground for various types of predators. The children unlucky enough to find themselves there are innocent and trapped victims.



After mass, in the dining hall, Kenny approaches Lucy. He tells her that he thinks she is brave, too. The staff, distracted by Howie's death, neither notice nor separate the two and they stand together, holding hands, for a long time. In the afternoon, taking advantage of the distraction, Kenny slips down to the dock where he steals the school's new boat. He heads north, hoping to reach Port McNeill and find his Uncle Clifford. In the afternoon, Kenny approaches a port city. He splashes to shore, leaving the boat afloat in hopes of making the authorities believe that he drowned. Then he sneaks onto the docks where he hides in a fishing skiff overnight.

In the morning, a fisherman named Mack discovers Kenny. Mack is an Indigenous person, too, and he knows Clifford. But at first, he plans to turn the boy in to the authorities, afraid of getting in trouble for harboring a runaway. Eventually, he relents and agrees to take Kenny to Clifford's boat. Clifford is also reluctant to let Kenny stay; the penalties are steep for harboring runaways. But, having been protected from the residential school system himself, he doesn't know how bad it is.

Kenny takes off his shirt to show Clifford his bruises and describes some of the starvation and abuse he's endured. He asks why his mother never visited or wrote, and Clifford explains that Kenny's mother Bella had tried to do both. But the school threatened to arrest her if she tried to visit, it intercepted the letters she sent to Kenny, and it ignored the letters she sent to Father Levesque. Clifford relents and tells Kenny he will take him home to his mother in Simpson.

Things are not as Kenny remembers them when he arrives in Simpson. Bella hasn't been using or maintaining the smokehouse where she and Kenny used to work together before he was taken to the mission school. She hasn't been maintaining her house, either, and in her despair has become an alcoholic. Still, she's happy to see Kenny again. Together, they clean the house and the smokehouse. When Clifford comes back with a bin of salmon for them, they work together smoking and preserving it. Each night, Bella tucks Kenny into his own bed, where he sleeps safely and soundly through the night. But the trauma of their years-long separation haunts both, and they begin to drift apart.

Without getting into gruesome detail, the book eloquently suggests the level of control the school authorities exercise. Most of the children are so broken and traumatized that they police their own behavior even in the absence of authority figures. But in disobeying strict rules segregating boys from girls—and generally trying to isolate the children from one another to break their spirits—Lucy and Kenny both make a claim for their own human dignity and show off their inner reserves of strength. And Kenny makes the ultimate statement of autonomy by running away.



Both Mack and Clifford hesitate to help Kenny, afraid of getting in trouble themselves. The abuses perpetuated by the residential school system were the consequence of a society that not only accepted the schools' mission but supported it with the full weight of the legal system. And while the degree of its success in breaking up families is almost on display here, Clifford bucks the pressure and decides to help Kenny out, showing his own bravery.



It's not until Clifford sees visual evidence of the abuse Kenny suffers that he relents—reminding readers that secrecy was the currency of the schools. The fact that abuse took place out of the public eye made it easier for it to continue. Clifford and Bella were lucky to escape experiencing such abuse themselves, but when they took her son, Bella found herself caught up in a system designed to destroy families regardless.



Kenny has tried so hard to get home because he still remembers it as a place of love, support, and safety especially after the school. But his loss broke his mother's heart and her spirit. The system worked the way its architects intended: it broke the connection between Kenny and his family. And it rendered his home unrecognizable. It's a testament to his—and Bella's—resilience that they make things work even for a time. And it's an indictment of the cruel and inhumane racism underwriting their separation when they fail.



Kenny takes odd jobs where he can, bringing the money home to Bella. When he's not working, he wanders around town. Bella can't stop drinking, and sometimes she disappears for days at a time. One day, Kenny finds her sitting near the empty smokehouse. He asks her if she's glad to have him home. She says she is, but that she feels like she cannot escape her trauma or her sadness. On December 31, 1967, Kenny returns home to find her drinking with two strangers. The next morning, he sets out to sea on a fishing run with Mack.

Kenny leaves home again, this time voluntarily, after he cannot remake a family with the equally wounded and traumatized Bella. Escaping the school hasn't solved Kenny's problems because it's only one part of a large system designed to systematically destroy Indigenous families. But this, too, shows Kenny's own inability to process and handle his trauma. For years, he's only had one solution to fall back on: running away. And he doesn't know how to do anything better to handle his problems.



CHAPTER 2: LUCY

On the day before her 16th birthday, Sister Mary gives Lucy a cardboard suitcase and tells her to pack her things. She will be leaving the mission the next day. Lucy is relieved: while all the students are supposed to age out at 16, sometimes the school keeps them longer, paying them a pittance to keep working as maids and cooks, especially if they don't have family members to ask questions. By lunchtime, Lucy's friend Edna has gossiped her good news all over the school. The girls want to know where Lucy will go. Sister Mary told her that the school would give her bus ticket to Vancouver. There, she plans to look for her friend Maisie, who aged out and left the school a year earlier. Although she only wrote to Lucy once, Lucy saved the envelope with Maisie's address on it.

Lucy's fears cast light on yet another often hidden abuse of the residential school system, namely keeping Indigenous children far beyond their government-mandated 10-year education. It's also clear at this moment that Lucy doesn't have a family to return to, although the book never addresses why. Yet despite this lack, Lucy isn't alone. She's formed thriving friendships with other girls at the school, and the mutual support of these relationships has helped her to survive despite the terrible conditions.



That night, Edna declares that the girls must have a going-away party for Lucy. When the nuns are asleep, she sneaks to the kitchen and steals a pillowcase full of freshly baked pastries. Lucy counts seconds while Edna is gone. She counts a lot, a nervous habit she picked up in her early days at the mission school. The girls put a pink candle in one of the pastries and sing happy birthday, then tease Lucy that her wish probably involves Kenny, with whom she was friends until he escaped the school.

The late-night party both emphasizes the resilience of children who refuse to let their abusers crush their souls and shows the scars that they bear as a result. Lucy's life-long obsessive-compulsive habits begin in the residential school as a clear response to the anxiety and trauma she suffers there.



In the morning, Lucy packs her meager belongings: a few bobby pins, a change of clothes, a toothbrush and hairbrush, and the pink envelope from Maisie. As a parting gift, Edna gives her a patchwork purse she made. Lucy can hardly believe that she's leaving as she follows Sister Mary to the docks after lunch, accepts a bus ticket voucher, St. Christopher prayer card, and \$25 from the nun. Then she climbs aboard the boat for the short trip across the bay. When they arrive in town, the pilot tells her she should make her way to the East Hastings neighborhood when she arrives in Vancouver, since there are "lots of [her] kind there."

Despite the clear intimacy and affection between the two girls, once Lucy leaves the school, she never hears from Edna again. After separating the children from their real families, the schools subsequently deprive them of the chosen families they assemble for themselves by sending them away so abruptly. Had Maisie not written, there's little chance Lucy would have been able to find her again. The ferryman's casual racism pointedly reminds readers that isolating Indigenous children may have been the specific task of the residential schools, but it was endorsed by white Canadian society more broadly.



On the bus ride, Lucy runs her fingers through her hair. The nuns shaved all the children (to prevent lice infestations) when they arrived. Then, when the girls' hair grew back, the nuns made them style it so it wouldn't look like "Indian hair." Head-shaving was a common punishment. Sister Mary shaved Lucy's head and made her wear a sign that said "I am a liar" when Lucy tried to tell her that Father Levesque had abused her. That was the day Lucy slipped Kenny—then undergoing his own punishment for an attempt to run away—her note. Now, as she remembers all this, she thinks about how frequently she and the others were punished for minor infractions, for the crime of being children.

Lucy dozes throughout the hours-long trip to Vancouver. When she disembarks, the bus driver tells her which bus she needs to catch to get to Maisie's address. The unfamiliar noise and bustle of the city—the open way boys and girls speak together, the smell of urine in the air, the fast-moving cars on the streets—fascinate and alarm her. Finally, she boards the trolley bus, where the driver tells her that she must have exact change for her fare. She doesn't—Sister Mary gave her only five-dollar bills—but a stranger named Walt puts a quarter into the machine for her.

Calling her "Juicy-Lucy," Walt invites Lucy to sit next to him. She shows him the envelope, and he says he can take her to the address, which is in his neighborhood. Lucy wonders if St. Christopher is looking out for her. But when she and Walt disembark, the bus driver warns her to be careful. Walt helps Lucy find Maisie's address, but when he rings the buzzer, the voice on the intercom says that they have the wrong place. Walt offers to let Lucy stay with him and his "old woman" (which, he must explain to her, means his girlfriend) that night.

Walt's girlfriend isn't there when he and Lucy arrive. He makes a sandwich for Lucy, then asks if she's ever been on a date. He has a friend he thinks she'll like, he says, and he insists on having that friend over that night to meet her, even though Lucy protests that she's tired. When Walt's so-called friend shows up, he takes Lucy to the bedroom, gropes her, and demands that she undress. Pretending that she wants to brush her teeth first, she grabs her suitcase and runs. On her way out the door, she overhears Walt bragging to his girlfriend about pimping her out. She runs all the way back to the building where she thought Maisie lived, and she hides overnight in a closet off the main entry.

Lucy's hair is a particularly fraught topic; the nuns cruelly use the girls' hair both as a means of punishment and a way to further cut off children from Indigenous culture. This also shows how little personal agency the children have—they can't even control their own bodies. And this extends to the sexual abuse Lucy suffered from Father Levesque. And to add insult to injury, rather than believing and protecting her, Sister Mary further victimized her. Yet through it all, Lucy never lost her sense of her own human dignity, as evidenced by her awareness of how wrong the system is.



Lucy's reaction to the city shows how ill-prepared she is to assimilate into any society after nearly a decade of isolation and imprisonment at the residential school. Worse, society sees her life as disposable and unworthy of protection. The school gave her money but didn't teach her how to use it, and the prayer card asking the patron saint of travelers can't keep her safe from questionable characters like Walt, who preys on her naivety.



Lucy's trust in Walt speaks to her naivety, but also to how badly starved for human kindness she was in the school. The abuse she suffered renders her vulnerable to further abuse in the outside world, practically dooming her to a life of tragedy. Further, the abuse she suffered at the hands of adults who were supposed to care for her has deprived her of the ability to discern who is and isn't trustworthy.



Lucy couldn't escape the sexual abuse from Father Levesque at the school, but she does escape Walt and his friend, showing how clever and strong she is when given the freedom to direct her own actions. Still, her desperate situation highlights how badly served she has been by the school. Not only have they failed to prepare her to face life on the outside, but they have also set her up to fail there. Her survival speaks to her own character alone.



In the morning, too exhausted to keep hiding, Lucy moves to the front step. When a building resident passes her, Lucy shows her the envelope. The woman replies that Maisie does live in the building; last night, Walt buzzed the wrong unit. The woman takes Lucy upstairs and knocks on the right door. Maisie opens it and Lucy jumps on her with a hug.

The previous day showed that Lucy can't survive in the outside world by herself, and the school gave her no help. Luckily, she finds Maisie. The degree to which she (or Maisie, or any other victim) succeeds speaks to her character. On the other hand, the degree to which she fails indicts the school for their failures.



CHAPTER 3: MAISIE

Telling her story in first person, Maisie describes how tightly Lucy clings to her. Lucy describes her terrifying experience the previous night with Walt. Maisie knows Walt. She explains that he's a pimp—a man who makes his money by forcing women to have sex—and warns Lucy to stay away from him. She wants to know why Lucy didn't write ahead so that she could meet her at the bus station. Lucy says that Sister left her almost no time to prepare. Maisie's behavior shocks Lucy: she smokes and swears. But she soon becomes comfortable as they reminisce about evil Sister Mary and start making plans for Lucy's future.

The narration's switch to the first-person perspective emphasizes Maisie's voice, asking readers to pay special attention to her story. In Lucy's eyes, Maisie is a success, having learned to navigate the outside world successfully in the year since she left the school. She immediately adopts Maisie as her protector and guide. Their shared stories from the school link them as intimately as sisters, and their storytelling suggests that they suffered much more there than the novel details.



Before long, Maisie's boyfriend Jimmy arrives. Lucy is shocked to see them talking freely, embracing, and kissing—boys and girls were strictly segregated at the mission school. Jimmy's parents—who had been through the residential school system themselves—took him into the United States to keep him from being taken. He can't imagine what Maisie and Lucy have experienced.

Lucy's shock over Maisie's habits reminds readers just how controlling the residential school was—and how bad its priorities were. Lucy has been sheltered from swear words but not protected from sexual abuse. Jimmy's inability to imagine the abuses of the schools points to how inhumane their conditions were—far beyond the scope of what people would normally consider acceptable.



When Jimmy takes Maisie and Lucy to lunch at a nearby Chinese restaurant called the Only, Walt saunters past the window. Lucy panics. Maisie rushes outside, chasing Walt down, yelling at him to leave Lucy alone and kicking him in the groin to show him how serious she is about protecting her friend.

The trauma Lucy and Maisie experienced lives on in their responses to stress: Lucy freezes and Maisie fights. And while both reactions are protective, neither is helpful for making one's way through life. These girls have been irrevocably shaped by the school.



The next morning, Maisie—jittery and anxious because Lucy's arrival prevented her from going out the previous night—wakes her friend and takes her to the Manitu, the seedy hotel where she works. Maisie's boss, Harlan, makes lascivious comments about Lucy, whom Maisie tries to shield. Clara, one of the other hotel maids, attended mission school with them, although she's much older. She vaguely remembers Lucy and Kenny, though.

Maisie hints that there's another aspect to her life in Vancouver. Though she doesn't yet let readers see what it is, it's clear that her life is more complicated than she's been letting on to Lucy. And that's saying something because her daytime life isn't easy: the cost of her independence is doing a degrading job for an unsavory man. Still, she is surviving.



Teaching Lucy to cook scrambled eggs for dinner that night, Maisie remembers helping her mom make spaghetti sauce when she was a little girl. When she turned 16, the school sent Maisie back to her parents. She arrived in their village along with dozens of other kids who had all grown up so much that most of the parents struggled to pick out their kids. Although she had spent years looking forward to her return, Maisie soon realized it wasn't home any longer. She found it hard to trust her parents' love. She knew they had not relinquished her, but she still felt betrayed because they weren't able to protect or rescue her. Being back at home painfully reminded her of the childhood that had been stolen from her. So she left and came to Vancouver. Soon after she arrived, she learned her mother had died.

After dinner, Maisie tells Lucy that she's going on a date with Jimmy. Lucy says she'll be fine alone as long as she can leave a window open. Ever since she started cleaning Father Levesque's rooms, not having fresh air makes her anxious. Maisie understands—she cleaned Father's rooms, too. Maisie dresses up as "Jimmy's girl"—clean, pretty, innocent—but she takes a bag full of bright red lipstick, revealing clothing, and leather boots with her. She rides the bus to another neighborhood where she changes clothes in the bathroom of a bar called the Knight and Day. Then she waits for the Old Man.

When he appears, Maisie follows the Old Man to an alley. She hands him a small candy bar then turns to face the wall. While he has sex with her, she makes him say the things Father Levesque used to, things like "Slut. Savage. Filth." She feels like this ritual is essential to her very survival. When he's done, the Old Man tucks two \$10 bills into her bra. Then he gives her the candy bar, just like Father used to do. After he leaves, she eats the chocolate, smokes a cigarette, changes back into her good-girl outfit, and goes home.

When Maisie gets back to her apartment, Lucy tells her that Jimmy had come by looking for her. Maisie avoids Lucy's questions. After taking a hot bath, she cuts the skin on her chest with a sharp knife. This ritual has already left dozens of scars beneath her collarbone. The pain makes her feel clean. When Jimmy shows up early the next morning, she sticks to her story about the mixed-up date, even though he knows she's lying. When the fight gets intense, she locks herself in her room to reopen her fresh cut. The pain helps her to feel like "Jimmy's girl" again. She goes back out to the living room, where she apologizes and makes plans with Jimmy to take Lucy sightseeing the next day.

In this extended flashback, Maisie gives readers a glimpse into what the mission school cost her and her family. Her difficulty reintegrating into her family and community speaks to the intergenerational nature of the trauma caused by the residential school system, which thus managed to touch even family members who were spared direct experience. Assimilation required separating Indigenous children from their families and their cultures—something that has retroactively been recognized as cultural genocide. Maisie's inability to trust her parents shows the success of these efforts.



Maisie reacts strongly to the subtle reminder of Lucy's—and her own—sexual abuse. It's notable that this is the last thing she talks about with Lucy before engaging in her metamorphosis from "Jimmy's girl"—the self she wants to be—into the bad girl who meets the Old Man. That personal reflects the messages she received at the school and through the abuse she suffered from Father Levesque. The seedy bar emphasizes the dichotomy of Maisie's personalities in its punny name—Maisie is a different person at night than she is by day.



The dirty alleyway where Maisie and the Old Man meet highlights and emphasizes the horror of what Maisie—and Lucy—suffered. Father Levesque treated them like trash, and Maisie absorbed the message that she isn't worth much more than trash from him. The abusive dirty talk, especially the use of the word "Savage" for Indigenous person, reminds readers that the individual acts of cruelty and abuse that Maisie suffered are tied to broader systems of racism and prejudice.



In the novel, Maisie exemplifies the worst outcomes of the residential school system. The novel clearly shows how all of her self-harming actions—the cutting, the reenactment of her sexual abuse, and the lies she tells the people around her—are symptoms of the traumatic abuse she suffered as a child. It's clear that although Maisie may have left the school physically, she remains mentally trapped in the cycles it taught her. It's a sign of her inner strength that she tries to keep going and to make things right for herself and with others.



Lucy is amazed by everything she sees on their outing. Her innocence both amuses and pains Maisie, who knows she must have looked much the same way a year ago when she first arrived in the city. Lucy finds the hippies particularly startling. She can only imagine what Sister would say about *them*. Jimmy chides Maisie and Lucy for “talking smack” about a woman whom he assumes was only “doing her job.” Maisie begins to argue with him, saying that he doesn’t know what he is talking about. He wasn’t there, and things happened there that he wouldn’t believe. Unable to leave well enough alone, Jimmy turns on Lucy and asks her to describe the worst thing that happened to her. She freezes. Telling him to “fuck right off,” Maisie storms home with Lucy.

Maisie goes back to the Knight and Day that night, driven by a compulsion to reenact her trauma. The Old Man gets there first, and he’s visibly shocked to see her in her good girl clothes. He’s brought a friend—a drug dealer named Steve—to give her a hit of heroin that he’s already paid for. She insists on sex first as Steve watches. Then he injects the drug into her vein, and a delicious euphoria envelops her. Plucking the two \$10 bills from her bra, Steve offers to sell her more whenever she wants. After he and the Old Man leave, Maisie loses consciousness. She comes to as police officer is forcing her into the back of his cruiser. He drives away without picking up the bag that contains her normal clothes and the only picture she has of her mother.

The next morning, the police release Maisie from jail. Without any money, she’s forced to walk all the way home in her bad girl clothes. When she sees her reflection in a shop mirror, she can barely recognize it. Lucy and Jimmy are waiting for her in the apartment. Jimmy expresses shock and disgust over Maisie’s appearance, and he accuses her of being a prostitute. Maisie’s heart breaks as she realizes that she lost her opportunity to be “Jimmy’s girl” before she ever left the mission school.

Jimmy storms out, and after a tearful scene, Maisie sends Lucy to work. She takes a long, hot bath. When she gets out and sees herself in the mirror, she sees a stranger. Dressing once more as Jimmy’s girl, she takes her identification and her last \$50 and heads to a park in a rough section of the city. Eventually, she calls the Old Man and asks him to send Steve over with more drugs and the necessary paraphernalia for shooting up. When he brings her the stuff, she promises to pay him back soon. After he leaves, she gives an old homeless woman her \$50, then she sits down next to a bush and overdoses. The last thing she sees is the city skyline.

During the day, Maisie slips back into her role as Lucy’s protector and guide, trying to give Lucy what her parents were unable to provide: help figuring out how to be an adult and how to live in the world after years of being sequestered in the school. In defending Sister Mary, Jimmy becomes novel’s voice for all the people who might wonder why residential school victims and survivors can’t—or don’t—just move on with their lives once they finally get out. The novel gives readers just a small glimpse into the horror of the school, but it’s enough to show why and how these experiences shape the rest of survivors’ lives.



Only after showing Maisie as Lucy’s friend and protector and after explaining some of her history at the school does the novel delve into her self-destructive behavior. It thus traces her maladaptive actions to their roots in the violence she suffered at the hands of religious and civil authorities. And it shows how hard it is to escape systemic racism and abuse. No one helps Maisie process or deal with her trauma—or even to help her gain the necessary skills to be a productive member of society. The only attention society pays is to arrest her for her disorderly conduct.



Maisie’s inability to recognize her reflection speaks to the ways in which the residential school permanently wounded her. Maisie wants to feel loved, valued, and clean—like “Jimmy’s girl”—but the school told her over and over that she was unworthy of that role. She can’t recognize herself in the good girl she wants to be or the bad girl she fears she is.



On her walk home, Maisie worried that her child self—her true self—was gone, destroyed by the residential school system and the ongoing racism and prejudice she’s had to face since she left. Jimmy’s reaction confirmed it in her mind. She takes her own life as a response to this feeling that she cannot escape her fate, even as her decision to do so in her good-girl persona suggests that she still has a choice. Thus, even this moment of finality suggests that a different outcome could have been possible, had Maisie not experienced such extreme abuse.



CHAPTER 4: KENNY

Kenny wakes up a little hung over in a picker's shack in Washington state. When he arrives late for work, the foreman refuses to make an exception for him—there are plenty more where Kenny comes from. He will dock Kenny's pay for the day. Frustrated, Kenny heads for the orchard, where he works alongside a newer picker named Wilfred. They pick more than the quota. Anticipating a bonus, Wilfred asks if Kenny wants to go for drinks after work. Kenny says he's trying to save his money to get his own place. Wilfred shares his yearning for freedom. He says that being bossed around always reminds him of mission school. Looking closer, Kenny and Wilfred finally recognize each other. Wilfred is particularly surprised. He and the other children were told that Kenny had drowned.

Even though he made up for being late by picking extra, the foreman refuses to pay Kenny fairly. Kenny's vision tunnels, and he flips the table, sending money flying everywhere. Pickers scramble to grab as much as they can as Kenny punches the foreman in the face. Rosa, an elderly Mexican picker, presses \$40 into Kenny's hand and tells him to run before the foreman can call the police. He and Wilfred take off.

Once they've made it to safety, Kenny starts to consider what he's done. He won't be able to get any more picking work this season. Wilfred pulls handfuls of crumpled cash snatched during from his pockets during the chaos. Like the old days at the mission school, they pool and split their resources. Then, Wilfred heads into town for some supplies. That evening, while Wilfred builds a fire and cooks some beans, he and Kenny talk about the fates of other mission school kids. Wilfred says that Lucy—his sister, as it turns out—is living in Vancouver. Howie, who survived Brother's brutal beating, escaped the school but ended up having to go back there to sort out a paperwork issue. He assaulted Brother, beating him severely, and he was jailed for it.

In the morning the old friends part ways. Kenny heads for Canada to look for Lucy and a job—Wilfred suggests logging, because it pays well. Wilfred plans to stick around for more picking work. Kenny enjoyed revisiting their stories of success and survival, seeing Wilfred also brought back less pleasant memories from the mission school. When he reaches Vancouver, Kenny asks after Lucy at the Manitou, but on the day he arrives, she isn't there.

It's been a few years since Kenny left home, although it's not exactly clear how many. This lack of specificity speaks to his own growing sense that he is living a suspended, aimless sort of life. He snatches what he can between drunken binges and panic-fueled flights from one place to another. Readers can also see the lingering effects of his trauma in the fact that he seems to have developed a problematic drinking habit, just like his mother. Still, he seems to be relatively stable—at least for now.



Just like Maisie, however, it's soon clear that the ghosts of Kenny's past experiences haunt him. Unfair treatment by the foreman picks open old wounds of unfair treatment by Brother and Sister Mary at the school. Then, he was too young to do anything about it, but now he can and does stand up for himself—just not in ways that are socially acceptable, because he was never given the tools or the opportunities to advocate for himself properly.



Just as they did when they were kids, Kenny and Wilfred instinctively watch out for each other when briefly reunited as adults. Their story shows, in part, how the victims of the residential school system kept some of their humanity by forging intimate, family-like bonds to replace the families that the authorities stole them from. And Wilfred foreshadows details from Howie's story, which the novel will expand on in a later chapter. Like Kenny's, Maisie's, and Lucy's stories, Howie's story illustrates some of the ways that indignities and suffering followed residential school victims throughout their lives.



Wilfred lives an itinerant life as a seasonal worker. He doesn't have much of a relationship with his sister—yet another testament to the determination of the residential schools to destroy family bonds. But he's not as rootless as Kenny, whose traumatic memories drive him to run away from anything—and anyone—who reminds him of his residential school past.



CHAPTER 5: LUCY

Many things have changed in Lucy's life since Maisie's death. She still works at the Manitou, but she lives in a new apartment, but she's finding her own style, and she's been taking classes. As she prepares to take the final exam for her last high school-level class, Clara and Liz cheer her on. When she passes, they celebrate with her. But Harlan mocks her, saying that "Indian chicks" are only good as prostitutes or maids and that he doesn't know why she went back to school. Offended, Lucy quits, prompting Harlan to call her an "ungrateful bitch." Instantly, Clara attacks him, punching at his back and head and screaming that he's ruining Lucy's "best day ever." He fires all three of them.

Lucy feels bad that she's cost her friends their jobs. But Clara figures Harlan will soon want to hire them back. Clara also tells Lucy that her "boyfriend" came looking for her at the hotel recently. Lucy is confused, but she puts it out of her mind while she goes to celebrate her success with her friends. When she gets home, Kenny is waiting by the door to her apartment. He's grown into a man, but she still recognizes him instantly. And while she's happy to see him again, it also brings old memories uncomfortably close to the surface for her. She invites him to come back the next day for coffee.

The next day, Kenny and Lucy talk over rum-spiked coffee in Lucy's apartment. She tells him that she knew from his behavior on the day that he would make another escape attempt. He tells her that she was the only thing that made him think twice about it. But he was so scared by what happened to Howie, he had to try. He tells her what he's heard about Howie's experiences. He tells her about making it home only to leave again because everything there had changed. She tells him about Sister putting her on a bus to Vancouver and about finding Maisie. And about Maisie's death. Finally, she tells him that she's been taking classes and now that she has her high school equivalent, she plans to go to nursing school.

Although Lucy invites him back for dinner, after Kenny leaves, he doesn't reappear for four days. He tells her that sometimes he just needs to be alone, and she understands. He asks to stay with her, and they talk late into the night. But he's gone in the morning. By the time Lucy begins nursing school two months later, she no longer expects to find him waiting by her door. But still, when Clara invites her to move in together, since Clara's place is closer to the community college, Lucy refuses. She wants to know that Kenny can find her if he comes back.

Although Maisie died, her legacy lives on in Lucy, who benefits from some of the things her friend helped her to figure out—like the job at the Manitou, which has supported her while she earns her degree. And Lucy sets her own example for others in her refusal to accept the tiny life the residential school prepared her for. Her success in school despite the odds testifies to her strength, determination, and bravery—the same traits Kenny admired in her.



Even though she lost Maisie, Lucy isn't alone—she's formed new friendships that provide the mutual support she (like all people) needs. Her ability to put down roots and see things through contrasts with Kenny's drifting lifestyle. But she doesn't judge him because she understands that his choices reflect and respond to his trauma, just like hers do. Maisie, in short, understands that she and Kenny are both doing the best they can with the circumstances they've had to face.



Lucy's and Kenny's mutual admiration is clear throughout their conversation. But it's also clear that their circumstances at the school forced them to put all considerations of friendship second to survival, and that this survival instinct has continued into adulthood. The ghosts of Howie and Maisie haunt Kenny and Lucy as examples of the lives they were lucky to escape. Readers can also see that the two share a strong work ethic and sense of responsibility to themselves and care for others.



Kenny's immediate disappearance testifies to the demons he carries with him. It's clear that his residential school experiences made permanent marks on his psyche. Lucy takes his departure with equanimity—even though it clearly makes her sad—and this, too, poignantly reminds readers of all that she's been through. From her parents to her brother Wilfred to her friend Edna and Maisie, she's had to face so many separations that she's prepared for this one.



CHAPTER 6: CLARA

On the night of Lucy's "best day ever," Clara stays at the bar long after Lucy and Liz leave. A white man tries to proposition her, saying that he heard "all you Indian chicks [are] easy," and when he refuses to leave her alone, she attacks him like she attacked Harlan. The bouncers escort her out. A police officer on the street warns her to get out of the neighborhood if she wants to avoid arrest. She tells him she's going home, but instead she wanders back to the Manitou where she spends a few hours sitting across the street at the bus stop, watching the sex workers and their johns come and go. She ruminates on Harlan's cruelty—not just the way he insulted Lucy, but also the times he's tried to coerce Clara into having sex with him.

Then Clara's memories return to the mission school, and her friend Lily. She remembers waking up on a brutally cold morning, then Lily succumbing to a coughing fit during morning prayers. Instead of worrying about Lily's ill health, Sister rebuked her for failing to "contain [herself]," then assigned her and Clara the unenviable chore of cleaning out the goats' enclosure. Only a few minutes after they started, Lily began to cough again. She collapsed with blood trickling from her mouth. Although Clara spent all day pleading with God to heal her friend in one "epic prayer," Lily died in the night.

Clara sees Lily's face in her mind's eye as she heaves a softball-sized rock through the front window of the Manitou. Its alarm sounds as she runs away, trying to get out of the area before the police respond. But the same officer who warned her off earlier catches her and throws her in the drunk tank. Clara finds a spot to sit between an old Indigenous woman and the window. The old woman points out the window at a small **birch tree** planted in the verge between the street and the sidewalk. The woman gently touches Clara and tells her that "the power of Creation is everywhere," even in her.

Clara goes back further into the past in her mind, remembering the walk home from church on her last day with her mother. As a child, Clara loved going to church, hearing the Bible stories, and singing the songs she learned in Sunday School. The homeward path wound through a grove of silver **birch trees**, and on that day, Clara thought she heard angels playing among them. The next morning, she and other children from the reservation were loaded on trucks and sent to the mission school, where Sister cut off her braids and forced her into a school uniform.

Clara entered Lucy's story as a dogged protector. This episode at the bar shows readers where some of her protectiveness comes from. But her anger arises from her own terrible residential school experiences and the ongoing racism, prejudice, and predatory behavior she's had to endure since. The book forces readers to confront the uncomfortable fact that many of the Indigenous women considered "easy" by people like the white man experienced abused at the hands of the adults charged with taking care of them when they were children.



Some of Clara's trauma arises from her perceived inability to protect her friend Lily, who died of tuberculosis. This and other highly contagious diseases circulated widely at residential schools thanks to poor nutrition, poor sanitation, and overcrowding. Sister's callous disregard for Lily's health—she seems to view the girl's illness as an attempt to shirk work—speaks to how inhumanely the staff at the mission school treated the children supposedly in their care.



Like Kenny and Maisie earlier, Clara perceives the relationship between her actions in the present and the things she suffered in the past. Smashing the window of the hotel owned and run by a white man she dislikes represents her attempt to fight back at the systems of oppression that victimized her and Lily by declaring that their Indigenous identities were unworthy of participating in white society. Clara is rewarded with a night in jail to sleep off the effects of her alcohol binge. Again, society sees—and punishes—the behavior without understanding its causes. But this marks a turning point for Clara. Seeing the birch tree from the jail window is a spiritual experience for her because it reminds her that there is more than just pain and suffering in the world.



Although this memory is as tinged with loss as that of Lily—the absence of Clara's mother from the novel's present implies that she's dead—it also reminds Clara that she has the capacity to forge meaningful relationships with other people. And her memory speaks to the violence of the school; although it was a religious institution, it destroyed Clara's sense of connection with the divine.



Clara shakes herself from her reverie and turns to speak to the old woman. But the old woman isn't there. In the morning, Clara asks the guard where she went, and he says that there was no old woman in the tank. He thinks Clara hallucinated it in her drunken stupor. Leaving the station, Clara bums a cigarette. She stands smoking it with her hand on the **birch tree**.

The school might have compromised Clara's spirituality, but it did not destroy it completely. Her mystical vision of the old woman proves that she can recover and heal that part of herself, if she chooses to. And the fact that she visits the birch tree on her way home hints that she will choose to, eventually.



CHAPTER 7: LUCY

Lucy starts her nursing program, but two months in, her morning sickness has become so bad that the matron in charge notices. She gently tells Lucy that she can't stay in the program, lest her out-of-wedlock pregnancy harm the program's reputation. Lucy is disappointed, but at least the matron is kind. Clara finds out about the pregnancy—and Lucy's leaving the program—a few days later when she drops by Lucy's apartment. When Lucy, having lost the nursing program's small stipend, loses her apartment, she moves in with Clara.

Lucy's pregnancy puts her at yet another disadvantage in the 1970s, when society had harsh views about babies born out of wedlock. But she doesn't have to face this alone. In Clara, she has a chosen sister to help her out. The schools may have deprived Lucy of her own parents and brother, and they have made it hard for her to form a traditional family with Kenny. But still, she finds a way to get the support she needs.



On the day that Lucy's baby girl is born, Clara goes to visit the pair in the hospital. When Clara finds out that Lucy hasn't seen her baby yet—she was born by C-section and Lucy was anesthetized—she brings it into the room. Lucy says she hadn't asked to see the baby because she was afraid that she wouldn't be allowed to have it, she's so used to the powers that be depriving her of "anything good." Lucy decides to name the girl Kendra, after her father, Kenny.

It's a sign of how successfully the schools—and the racism and prejudicial policies of society broadly speaking—succeeded in destroying Indigenous children's sense of belonging to their families and their culture that Lucy can't quite imagine the hospital willingly allowing her to parent her own baby. She's come to accept their view that Indigenous people like her don't deserve the good things in life.



When Clara comes to visit the next day, she finds a panicked Lucy clinging to Kendra and weeping. The "welfare lady" stopped by and told the new mother that she would have to prove her fitness as a parent if she wanted to keep her baby. She doesn't know if the nurses don't trust her or if welfare comes after every Indigenous person. Calmly, Clara walks down the empty hallway to a supply closet, where she stuffs diapers and other things into her backpack. She asks the nurse if she can take her friend outside for some fresh air and the nurse says yes. Clara loads Lucy and Kendra into a wheelchair and the three escape the hospital. They go back to Clara's place.

It seems that Lucy's suspicion that "they"—the society that sent her to the mission school and then consigned her to a life on its fringes—won't let her have anything good is well founded. Historically speaking, welfare officials in Canada in the 1960s and 1970s did take many Indigenous children from their parents based on a presumption of ineptitude. But Lucy's fears also speak to the intergenerational violence of the residential school system: having been taken from her own family, how will Lucy know what to do with her own child?



Clara had the foresight to give the hospital a fake address when she checked Lucy in, so she's not worried about the authorities finding them. But there are other struggles. The next day, Clara comes home to find Lucy trying to calm an inconsolable Kendra. The two women become increasingly anxious until Clara thinks to look through the booklets they brought back from the hospital. Reading about how to care for a newborn, they think to burp Kendra, and as soon as Lucy does, Kendra calms down. Later that night, Kendra shows Lucy the fake ID she's just gotten. Money is a problem. Lucy has no income and Clara makes irregular money selling black-market salmon. They need something more regular to count on if they're going to take care of Kendra.

Clara and Lucy don't know what to do with Kendra because neither of them grew up in their families, where most people pick up their ideas about caring for children. Because the government stole her from her own family at such a young age, all she has is the literature provided by the hospitals. Nevertheless, the love she and Clara have for Kendra and their determination to care for her mean that they figure out what to do, even if it's harder for them than it should be.



The next day, "Carey St. Marie" (Clara) and her sister-in-law, "Bunny St. Marie" (Lucy) and niece "Honey St. Marie" (Kendra) to the welfare office. It takes a few meetings, but eventually, both Clara and Lucy are awarded welfare stipends. They look for a bigger place, eventually finding a decrepit and disgusting two-bedroom house whose landlord doesn't automatically turn them away for being Indigenous women. Some of Clara's friends from the Indian Centre, including George and his wife Vera, help the women clean up the house and make it habitable. Life seems easy for a while, and Lucy is happy. But soon Clara becomes restless. One morning just a few days after Kendra's first birthday, Lucy wakes to find a note saying that Clara has taken off for a few weeks.

The effort and love Clara and Lucy pour into raising Kendra testifies to their strength and resilience even when the odds are stacked against them. Renting the house marks a turning point for Lucy and Kendra: they're finally putting down real roots and claiming a place to call their own. Notably, they don't do this alone: turning the squalid building into a warm and welcoming home is the work of an expanding community of friends that now includes George and Vera.



CHAPTER 8: CLARA

Clara's restlessness grew after she, Lucy, and Kendra moved into the house, but it had started before that. After Harlan fired her, she had begun spending more and more time at the Indian Friendship Center. There, she followed American Indian Movement actions on the television. Then one day, George and Vera and other AIM activists held a meeting at the Center. At first, their overt embrace of the symbols of Indigenous culture—including bone chokers and beaded jewelry—made her uncomfortable. Sister would not have approved. But she was deeply moved as George talked about protests at Alcatraz, the Trail of Broken Treaties, and the occupation of Wounded Knee. Clara was stunned—and excited.

Clara's innate desire to protect others and to seek to redress the injustices she and others have suffered naturally draws her to George and Vera and into the American Indian Movement. AIM activists engaged in many high-profile actions designed to draw attention to the plight of Indigenous people like the ones described here, all of which took place in the United States in the late 1960s and early 1970s. One of the things that moves Clara is the AIM's proud and visible embrace of the emblems of Indigenous heritage that had so long been used to segregate them from mainstream society and prove that they were unworthy to participate in white society.



Now, Clara and her dog, John Lennon, head for the Canadian-American Border. The Canadian border guard rips apart her car, strewing clothing and dog food across the pavement as he interrogates Clara. She keeps her cool and he eventually stops harassing her when he realizes how traffic is backing up behind her. He drops her Indian Card on the ground instead of handing it back to her, forcing her to bend down to retrieve it. She does, but she waits until he isn't looking at her. As she crosses the border, she sings along—loudly—to her favorite Buffy St. Marie songs. And she thinks about how she fell in with George, Vera, and the AIM movement.

Clara stops for breakfast at a diner she frequents on her trips to the states to visit George and Vera. As she drives east, she reminisces about her first meeting with George, how he told her the AIM movement couldn't be stopped because it arose from so many directions at once. His words reminded her of hearing voices on the wind on her last walk home from church with her mother. She fled the room, weeping, and he chased her down, caught her into an embrace, and held her until she stopped crying.

Long after midnight, Clara arrives at George and Vera's house. They live on a reservation outside of Billings, Montana. They visit comfortably for an hour until their talk turns to the following day. George and Vera are supporting a group of Indigenous people resisting the sale of their reservation's land to oil and gas interests, backed by the American government. Clara is going to help them smuggle weapons to the besieged resistance on the Willow Flats reservation.

In the morning, George bolts a long box to the underside of Clara's car, which he, Clara, and Vera fill with guns and ammunition. The plan is for him and Vera to create a distraction at the Willow Flats checkpoint so that Clara—unknown to the US government—can slip through easily. Then she will deliver the munitions to the resistance, which is holed up at a church. The National Guard is supposed to let anyone with a white flag through. Thanks to George's distraction, Clara gets onto the reservation easily enough. But before she gets to the church, National Guardsmen want to search her car. Clara panics, guns her engine, and flees. She can hear the sirens in the distance as the Guardsmen chase her down, and she runs off the road into a ditch, losing consciousness.

Clara's primary engagements with white society come from interactions with legal authorities—police and border guards. Racism and prejudice poison these interactions, which the book casts as representative of mainstream society's attitudes toward Indigenous people. On the infrequent occasions when white people are nice to Clara, they're civilians. Still, she keeps a lid on her temper here, showing that she's maturing thanks to George and Vera's friendship and to having a cause toward which she can direct her rage.



The American Indian Movement gathered Indigenous people from various nations together under the banner of their shared Indigenous heritage and rights. It forged new bonds to replace the traditional ones destroyed by the power of conquest and assimilation. Likewise, George shows Clara how personal and political families can be linked.



The situation at Willow Flats mirrors historical events like the Occupation of Wounded Knee in 1973, in which 200 activists seized control of the city in South Dakota to demand the impeachment of an Oglala Sioux tribal president whose actions undermined Oglala interests. Modern readers might also catch allusions to similar 21st-century actions by Indigenous people in the United States and Canada to prevent the oil and gas companies from accessing Indigenous lands.



As in historical parallels, the US government intervenes on the side of the oil and gas companies rather than the Indigenous people whose lands it is bound by treaty to respect. And this episode demonstrates the importance of mutual aid and friendships to advocacy movements: George and Vera (and by extension the Willow Flats traditionalists) cannot succeed without the help of friends like Clara. But AIM's activism isn't without danger, and Clara also showcases her bravery and resilience by going through with the mission despite its dangers.



Clara comes to in the antiseptic environment of a hospital room. George is there. He and Vera found her—protected by John Lennon—the morning after her accident. They had her car towed and brought her to the hospital, where doctors operated on her shoulder. When Clara complains about her pain to a condescending doctor, he orders more morphine for her, which puts her to sleep. When she wakes up again, George has left to get food. In his absence, two FBI agents visit Clara and attempt to interrogate her. She sticks to her cover story until George returns and forces the men to leave. Then he and Clara sneak out of the hospital and back to Montana, where an ecstatic John Lennon greets his owner.

The bonds that tie George, Vera, and Clara are strong. Each is willing to protect and support the others despite the dangers to themselves. Abandoned—if not directly vilified or victimized—by mainstream white society, the Indigenous characters in the book can still rely on one another. And they come through for one another every time. George sneaking Clara out of the hospital parallels Clara sneaking Kendra and Lucy from the hospital in Vancouver. Despite all that white society has taken away from them, Clara and her circle not only survive, but they also help one another out.



George, Vera, and Clara plan Clara's escape to Canada. It's risky, but she's going to have to sneak across illegally through Indian reserve lands near the crossing at Climax, Saskatchewan. The trio (and John Lennon) drive north the following day, killing time at a diner and at a local park so that Clara can cross under cover of darkness. She makes her way to a seldom-used service road but is immediately intercepted by border agents and RCMP. She and John Lennon abandon the car and run toward a row of houses where they hope to find shelter with the reserve's residents. Three men run into the fields to delay the border agents while a mysterious woman helps Clara clamber into a pickup truck and drives her away under cover of darkness.

Despite their closeness, there's a practical and geographic limit to how much George and Vera can help Clara. Fortunately, they are tapped into a broader community of Indigenous activists and individuals, and where their direct help to Clara ends, others step in to offer aid. This scene emphasizes how her community continues to grow broader and deeper.



CHAPTER 9: HOWIE

At his seventh parole board hearing, Howie makes a statement before the board can ask him any questions. He doesn't want to waste their time. He knows that he's supposed to say he regrets beating Brother and that he's changed in prison. But he isn't sorry, and he hasn't changed; beating Brother was the aberration in a life of not causing trouble for anyone. One of the parole board members reminds Howie that it's their job to "protect the public safety." Howie demands to know who was protecting his safety, and the safety of the other mission school children. The sympathetic guard who escorts Howie back to his cell encourages him to play the parole board's game and say the things they want to hear. But Howie has too much dignity to lie.

Howie's story, like Maisie's, begins in the first person (although by his next chapter it switches back to third person). This allows readers to hear not only his unapologetic defense of the actions he took against Brother but also to inhabit his perspective as he listens to what the parole board members say to him. Their protests about protecting the public ring hollow in light of what happened at the school. It seems that society is far more concerned with keeping Indigenous people under control than ensuring their safety.



Much to his surprise, when the parole board's decision comes down a few weeks later, they grant Howie's conditional release. On the day he leaves, he tries to refuse the prison's offer of a ride into town. He savors the wide sky and the breeze on his face as he walks through farmland which reminds him of the happy part of his life, after he and his mother escaped to Oklahoma. But a police officer eventually catches up to him on the road and insists that he ride. Climbing into the back of the cruiser like a prisoner or a suspect yet again nauseates Howie, but he makes it into town, where he catches a bus to Vancouver.

Some of the guys in prison have told Howie where to go in Vancouver to get his prison check cashed, since of course he doesn't have a bank account anywhere. He gets more and more anxious as the teller must repeatedly confer with the manager—first to cash the government check and then to accept Howie's only form of ID, an expired Oklahoma driver's license—but eventually she counts his cash out onto the counter. Afterwards, Howie wanders around the neighborhood until he finds a diner called the Two Jays, where he stops in and orders an enormous meal from a kind waitress (later identified as Connie). She also tells him where he can rent a room inexpensively.

The next morning, Howie luxuriates in the shower of the shared bathroom, annoying the other guests. But he doesn't care. He returns to the Two Jays for breakfast, where he also peruses the wanted ads in the paper. Afterwards, he boards a bus toward Stanley Park. He watches through the window as the scenery shifts from skid row to downtown department stores, to upscale neighborhoods and finally to the rich greenery of the park. He spends the rest of the day slowly relaxing as he walks on verdant trails and visits the zoo's female wolf. Eventually, he returns to the skid row neighborhood where he's staying and heads to the Two Jays for dinner.

Mindful of his dwindling cash supply, Howie orders much less food than he did the previous night. Connie notices, and it confirms her suspicion that he's an ex-con. She graciously adds a free slice of pie to his dinner and tells him that she can help him get a job unloading beer at the Balmoral because she knows the proprietor. She also, finally, tells Howie her name—she refuses to wear her nametag so that customers can't harass her as easily.

Howie has been locked up twice, first as a child in the mission school, and then as an adult in prison. Although the book doesn't specify his chronology, it implies that he's spent far more of his life locked up than free. And so, when he gets out of prison, he wants to insist on his autonomy. But society has little tolerance for Indigenous autonomy. Even now, Howie remains subject to surveillance and control.



In the face of broader society's lack of concern (or direct ill-will), Howie finds support among other Indigenous people he meets in prison. The bank teller's willingness to help him and to cash his check stands out as a counterexample to broader society's attitude toward Indigenous people in this book, which is one of barely concealed distrust and dislike. Connie is kind to Howie too, but the book also implies here (and confirms later) that she's an Indigenous woman.



Howie's appreciation for the shower reminds readers by contrast how much pleasure and comfort his years in prison denied him. His bus ride through the city pointedly reminds readers of the places to which society consigned Indigenous people even after they escaped the residential school system—they're not allowed into the nice parts of town more than temporarily. But Howie is still grateful to be free after so many years locked away. Unlike the zoo's wolf, he has hope and the potential to make a better future for himself.



Individual acts of human kindness cannot undo the damage of systematic abuse, but as here, they do soften it a bit. The fact that Connie seems used to Indigenous ex-cons suggests that they're a common occurrence. This, in turn, points yet again toward the racism in a society that stacks the odds against men like Howie.



When Connie's shift ends, she walks Howie to the Balmoral, where she introduces him to the owner, Mike. The atmosphere is thick with the stench of beer, urine, puke, and cigarette smoke, and the noise and chaos of the patrons—a fight seems to break out every few minutes—unnerves Howie. Mike offers to pay him \$10 a day to come in at 7:00 a.m., unload the daily alcohol delivery, sweep the barroom, and clean the bathrooms. Howie gratefully accepts. Afterward, Connie refuses his offer to walk her home—she must take the bus to her place—but she does accept his invitation for a date on her next day off.

Howie shows up at the Balmoral the following morning determined to do the kind of good job his family taught him to take pride in. The bar and bathrooms are a disgusting sight when he starts. But by the time Mike arrives, they're sparkling clean. Impressed with Howie's work ethic, he offers to hire him as a bouncer, too. But Howie declines, saying he's not good with crowds. Back at his hotel room, Howie reads the wanted ads without finding any promising leads. He falls into a sleep disturbed by dark, traumatic dreams.

For their date, Howie takes Connie to Stanley Park. She wants to ride the train, and while they do, Howie tells her about the train trip he took with his mother to visit his aunt the summer before he went to the mission school. Then he finds himself telling her about the mission school and his escape to the United States. Connie has an inkling of what he suffered; father survived the residential school system and gave up his Indian status to keep her from suffering the same fate. Her mixed-race mother was exempt. Howie brings Connie to visit the wolf, whom he sees as a kindred spirit. Before he was locked up, he loved the freedom and isolation of the American high desert.

Days and weeks pass, and Howie becomes increasingly desperate to find a real job. Nightmares and mission school flashbacks plague him at night. When he's unable to sleep, he takes long midnight walks. One route takes him through the grounds of a Catholic cathedral. One night, when he's feeling particularly overwhelmed, he breaks into the cathedral and steals a valuable gold crucifix. As he takes it, he thinks of all the brutality and indignities he and other Indigenous children suffered at the hands of the church. When he tries to pawn it, however, he's quickly caught and arrested. But the arguments of his court-assigned paralegal earn him a conditional release. If he stays out of trouble for a year and seeks job training at the Indian Friendship Center, the theft charges will be dropped.

Opportunities for men like Howie are few and far between, so despite the disgusting atmosphere, he gladly accepts Mike's job offer. This reminds readers of the limited opportunities that society accorded to Indigenous people. Howie accepts the job because he doesn't have much of a choice and because he's determined to make a better life for himself despite the odds.



Howie never addresses specifically why he can't handle crowds, but his words imply that it's related to his time at the mission school and prison. The limitations his experiences place on his life are, in some ways, less obvious than with other characters like Kenny, who can't stay in place for long, but they impact Howie's life, nevertheless.



Like Jimmy, Connie was spared the residential school system. Unlike him, she doesn't question Howie's experiences or imply that he could—or should—simply walk away from what happened to him. Howie shows Connie the wolf as a sort of metaphor for his own experience. It's a noble creature that should be free to live in its true environment and according to its own habits. But it has been captured and caged in much the same way society wants to consign Indigenous people to limited (and often unpleasant) roles. Like the wolf, Howie knows he can't ever return to who he was or where he belonged before he was locked up. But he's free now—which suggests he might still be able to make a good life for himself.



Howie has escaped the school and left prison, but he can't escape the systems that underwrite those institutions—systems designed to keep Indigenous people like him circumscribed. It's not surprising, then, when he turns to petty crime out of desperation. These facts underwrite the Courtworker's defense—that neither the school nor the prison prepared him for life in regular society. The Courtworker asks the judge—and readers—to consider that treating people with compassion and dignity will have far better effects for individuals and society than punishing the oppressed for petty crimes.



CHAPTER 10: MARIAH

Returning to Clara's escape from the law a few years earlier, she wakes in the unfamiliar darkness of the remote countryside. She's disoriented, but she hears John Lennon howling nearby. When she tries to bring him inside the cabin she finds herself in, the Old Woman (later identified as Mariah) tells her that dogs stay outside. If Clara must be with him, she can build a fire in the stove on the porch and sleep with him there. That's just what Clara does: John Lennon refused to abandon her on the night of the car crash, and she won't abandon him now.

The next morning, when John Lennon and Clara wake up, Mariah isn't in the cabin, so they investigate the surrounding woods. They discover the sweat lodge woven out of live willows in a nearby clearing, structure. John Lennon won't go near it, and this unnerves Clara. The woods around the cabin are filled with a tinkling noise that reminds her of the sounds of her childhood. Eventually, she sees that Mariah has hung old glass bottles in the trees and they act as windchimes.

It's late afternoon when Clara and John Lennon return to the cabin, and soon afterward Mariah reappears, too. She makes some fresh bannock bread for Clara, then begins to prepare venison stew, putting Clara to work peeling potatoes. Her ease in the kitchen reminds Clara of her own mother. Mariah explains that her grandmother raised her in this remote cabin; after her mother's death her father brought her there to keep her out of the residential schools. She's been there ever since, surviving on what she can hunt and trap and what her friends bring her.

Mariah is a healer. She inspects Clara's wounded (and now infected) shoulder and expertly cleans and dresses it. She's a spiritual healer, too, but Clara doesn't think she needs spiritual healing, even after she found out that Vera made arrangements to spirit her here from the reservation. Mariah invites Clara to visit the sweat lodge and encourages her to pray and rediscover her connection with her ancestors. Clara balks at the idea: neither the Catholic God to whom she prayed nor her ancestors saved her or Lily from residential school.

The previous chapter ended with Howie getting a chance to redeem himself. Now the novel turns back to Clara, who began to redeem her troubled past after she got involved with the AIM. But thus far her involvement has been fueled by her rage and pain. Mariah offers Clara a lesson in compromise that foreshadows what she has to teach the younger woman about finding strength in peace, not pain.



Mariah's cabin and its environment suggest a deep connection with the land. This, in turn, offers a sense of home: the very thing that Clara and all the other residential school kids have been denied their whole lives. By staging important episodes of Clara's growth here, the book not so subtly suggests the necessity of having a stable place in the world—the very thing the residential school system denied to its victims.



The feeling of comfort and safety Clara gets from working in the kitchen with Mariah reinforces the importance of home and family in life. Mariah becomes a surrogate mother figure for Clara, something she can do easily because she was nurtured by her own family. The book suggests that people truly learn to help others only through being in this kind of foundational, family relationship.



Clara's reckless behavior has already proved that her emotional wounds are just as serious as her physical ones. In a symbolic sense, these emotional wounds are infected and are poisoning her life, preventing her from reaching her full potential. Although she resists the idea of the sweat lodge for now, it's clear that she will end up there eventually.



Nevertheless, Clara settles into a peaceful routine with Mariah over the winter. Mariah cooks, tends to Clara's healing shoulder, and teaches her to work the trapline. Clara makes sure that there's enough wood for the woodstove. Mariah also introduces Clara to the people who come to visit the sweat lodge. But Clara still resists joining in. One night, Mariah asks Clara to present gifts of food to the ancestors in preparation for the rituals. Clara takes a plate of food to the sweat lodge, but even with the encouragement of another participant, she refuses to offer a prayer of thanks.

The next morning, Mariah finds Clara out on the trapline. She warns the younger woman that unless she seeks healing for her spiritual wounds, too, she will suffer needlessly. Later in the day, Clara finally tells Mariah about Lily and the guilt and anger she still feels over her friend's death. She also tells Mariah about her happy childhood and how sure she was of her connection with the spiritual realm—before residential school. She says that although she walked away, she doesn't feel like she survived it any more than Lily did. Mariah gently tucks an exhausted Clara into bed, and in the morning, Clara finally agrees to go to the sweat lodge. She emerges a changed woman.

In the spring, George and Vera come to bring Mariah more supplies and to collect Clara. Their reunion is a joyful one—for months they've wondered what happened after they parted at the border. Clara invites Mariah to come back to Vancouver with her, but Mariah refuses. Her life is in this cabin, where "broken wings" come to be healed. Before Clara leaves, Mariah blesses her and reminds her that she will always have access to spiritual guidance and a safe place to return to if she ever needs it.

CHAPTER 11: KENNY

Eventually, Kenny finds Lucy and Kendra again. And although he desperately wants to be part of their lives, he struggles to stay in one place for any extended period. But on one visit to Vancouver when Kendra is a toddler, he asks Lucy to marry him. At first, she holds off—she's afraid he's just going to leave again. But Kenny he finds work in the city, and for a while, he seems stable. Kendra flourishes. The family spends lots of time together on Kenny's days off, visiting local parks and the beach. But the urge to flee grows in Kenny, and the Monday after his and Lucy's City Hall Wedding, he makes breakfast, puts on his work boots, kisses his wife and daughter goodbye, and flees back to the logging camp. Although he regularly sends money home to Lucy, he knows she must be angry and disappointed.

The winter is healing to Clara because she's finally involved in the rhythms of nature and of family life. Importantly, she's also involved in the spiritual life of Indigenous people—something she's never had access to before. Remember that even before she was taken to the residential school, she and her mother attended the Catholic church on their reserve. Clara lost her faith in that institution and in its God when Lily died. But Mariah quietly and insistently suggests that this doesn't mean that her spirituality is inevitably lost, too. She just needs to open herself to other ways of experiencing it.



It takes a long time before Clara feels safe and secure enough to admit her pain to another person. Like many of the other victims, although she physically left the school, the emotional wounds she carries with her trap her in the past. Indirectly, she thus answers the question Jimmy posed in an earlier chapter. She doesn't move on because she can't—not without a lot of effort, time, and support. And not everyone has the opportunities for healing that Mariah offers Clara.



Clara wants to take Mariah—her new surrogate mother figure—back to the city with her, but Mariah knows that there are many more people like Clara out there already who need her too. And now that Clara has had some healing of her own, she becomes, like George and Vera, the kind of person who can inspire and help others.



Kenny and Lucy try very hard to form a stable family for themselves and for their daughter, but the unhealed wounds of their residential school experiences continue to fester, poisoning their attempts. It's clear that Kenny wants to stay at least as strongly as he feels driven to leave, and much of the pathos in his story arises from this conflict. He has a noble, loving, and loyal character, but the schools compromised his ability to be the person he truly is, deep down. And this, in turn, visits trauma on Kendra, even though she herself is spared the first-hand experience of attending the residential school.



One day, Kenny receives a letter from Clara informing him that Lucy has fallen seriously ill and been hospitalized. The kind and understanding foreman gives Kenny his paycheck and a ride to the ferry, expressing his hope that Kenny—such a conscientious worker—will come back after his wife has recovered. Clara is furious when Kenny finally arrives in the city. She berates him for abandoning his wife and daughter. Lucy is initially angry, too, but she soon softens toward Kenny. She knows he can't fight the urge to flee. But she warns him that if he can't stop, he'll owe Kendra an explanation one day. The day after she's discharged, she encourages Kenny to go back to the logging camp, hopeful that if he leaves before he feels he *must*, he might also be able to come home sooner.

Although Kenny can't be the husband and father he wants to be, Lucy and Kendra still have Clara to rely on. And Kenny benefits from Lucy's love, even if it's not enough to heal all his psychological wounds. This chapter emphasizes Lucy's and Kenny's resilience and their willingness to keep trying and to keep supporting and loving each other even when their efforts are imperfect. And the quiet beauty of their mutual love throws into stark contrast the violence of the system that traumatized them both.



CHAPTER 12: CLARA

The story returns to a year or so earlier, when Clara left Mariah's place with George and Vera. They take her to Vancouver, where they are due to give a presentation at the Friendship Center. After months at Mariah's, living with the simple rhythms of nature, Clara finds the speed of the outside world overwhelming. She wonders what she will do with herself when she gets back to the city—she's certainly not going back to the Manitou. George and Vera drop her and John Lennon off at Lucy's house, where Clara is surprised to find Kendra already walking. There's new furniture, too, provided by Kenny on one of his short visits. Clara neither likes nor trusts Kenny, but Lucy sticks up for him.

Like Kenny, Clara has her own episodes of wandering—and also like Kenny, she always comes home to Lucy and Kendra. Their tiny family unit becomes the anchor for the five of them as they navigate the world and try to deal with the trauma they've each experienced. The book thus highlights the importance of having a family and a home, even when people must figure out how to cobble them together for themselves without help or a solid pattern to go by. In many ways, by dint of her geographic stability, Lucy becomes the mother to everyone in her chosen family, not just Kendra.



Two days later, when Clara goes to the Friendship Center for George's presentation, she discovers a sign on a bulletin board advertising the Native Courtworkers' Society. The Courtworkers provide free services for Indigenous people in the legal system. Clara copies down the number, calls the Society and soon, she has embarked on the six-month training course necessary to be certified under the mentorship of a woman named Rose.

Clara's time with Mariah gave her an opportunity to heal some of her physical and emotional wounds. She's now ready for the next step in her journey, which the notice on the bulletin board provides. The Courtworkers advocate for and protect vulnerable Indigenous people in the court system, and starting a career as one gives Clara the opportunity to use her protective instincts proactively instead of reactively or destructively.



Clara struggles to understand how Rose can adopt—and maintain—such a calm and polite demeanor despite the way that some judges treat their Indigenous clients. Rose explains that it isn't her job to change the world or to confront individual prejudice, but to keep Indigenous people out of jail. Mouthing off will threaten that mission. And it won't help their clients. This is a tough pill for Clara to swallow at first, but over the months of her training, she eventually realizes that Rose is right. Lucy helps Clara study in the evenings, when Kendra is asleep, and although she nearly freezes on test day, Clara passes and is soon hard at work advocating for others. Her first client is a teenager just released from residential school at 18, who shoplifted some apples from a grocery store because the school sent him away with neither food nor money.

Like Mariah, Rose takes on a maternal role as Clara's mentor. She helps Clara to understand how to channel her feelings toward making the world better rather than wasting her energy in useless destruction. Clara's actions still emphasize the injustices and cruelty the residential school system visited on Indigenous people and the racism which created and sustained those injustices and cruelties, though. Her first client is a victim like Clara, Lucy, and the others, kept at the school for as long as he was useful, then abandoned arbitrarily—the school system, it's clear, has no real concern for the client's wellbeing. Nor does the criminal justice system which would, without people like Clara, simply lock him up again, further victimizing him.



CHAPTER 13: HOWIE

Flashing forward again to after Howie's arrest for theft, Clara spends six months counseling him and helping him to establish himself. By the end of that time, she means so much to Howie that he immediately asks her out to dinner at the Only. There, he tells her the story of how he ended up in the mission school.

The blossoming romance between Howie and Clara tracks the slow process of their rehabilitation. Both will carry the scars of their experiences for the rest of their lives. But, the book suggests, as they find ways to forge meaningful lives for themselves, they can—and will—find a measure of peace.



In the story, Howie is five years old, living with his mother Sagastis on a reservation in Saskatchewan. When Sagastis's sister Mae, who followed her white husband Charlie to the logging communities of British Columbia, sends money for train tickets, they head west for a visit. Howie is excited, and he finds the train trip fascinating. Auntie May's house and its modern conveniences are even more fascinating; on the reservation, he grew up without electricity or running water. It's an enchanted summer for Howie. He celebrates his sixth birthday at Mae's house with streamers, store-bought cake, and a hotdog roast. Mae gives him a set of toy cars. But the local priest, passing by as they celebrate in the yard, finds out about Howie's birthday.

Of all the characters, Howie gives readers the clearest impression of what his life was like before residential school. And while the reservation on which he grew up lacked modern conveniences, his mother took good care of him, and he had a happy life there. The church's and state's claims about helping or civilizing the children kidnapped into the residential school system are shown here to be utterly false and totally malicious. What's worse, the authorities felt so entitled to control Indigenous lives that Mae's local priest thinks it's in his scope of authority to take Howie, even though Howie doesn't have any connection with that priest or his community.



A few days later, on the eve of their return home, the priest returns with a police officer and kidnaps Howie over Sagastis's protests that she will send him to school in Saskatchewan. Howie isn't too scared or worried when he first arrives at the mission school. He trusts his mother to rescue him. But he's not happy either; he begins wetting the bed and must endure teasing from the other children and abuse from Sister Mary because of it. As the year turns from fall to winter to spring and back to fall, and as one year turns to three, his hope slowly disappears. Still, he finds a friend in Kenny.

Howie's experiences at the school bear witness to the violence of the system. Wetting the bed is clearly a reaction to the stress of being kidnapped, yet it's treated as a choice or a character defect. He and others are punished for infractions they cannot control. And his story brings home to readers the horror of feeling like he's been abandoned by the mother whom he loved and trusted without reservation. The fact that he can find a friend amid these circumstances testifies to the strength of his spirit—and the need of all people to be loved and to love others.



The day after the beating, Howie wakes up in the hospital with no memory of leaving the school. He just remembers Brother coming for him and hitting him so hard he lost consciousness. He enjoys his time in the hospital because the nurses are kind and because Auntie Mae (but not Sagastis) is allowed to visit him. Mae tells Howie that his family has a plan to take him away from the school by boat. All he has to do is meet them at the dock under the cover of darkness.

After another week of recuperating in the hospital, Howie returns to the school. When he tells Kenny about his escape plan, Kenny promises to help. That night, Kenny jimmyes the fire escape door for Howie who rushes down to the dock and onto Charlie's boat. They race across the bay where Howie and Sagastis jump into a waiting car and head for the US-Canada border. As they go, Auntie Mae presses one of Howie's tiny toy cars—a red one—into his hand. As he finishes his story, he asks Clara if she thinks that they will ever be able to free themselves from the long shadow of the mission school. In answer, she tells him about her visit to Mariah.

Like the others, Howie merely hints at the horrific abuse he suffered. And even the small bit of his experience that he shares with Clara is shocking for its brutality. Readers are left to imagine how much worse what's left unsaid must be. His fate at the school must be terrible if being hospitalized for severe injuries feels like a vacation.



Kenny risks punishment of his own to help his friend, testifying both to his own generous and caring nature and to the strength of the bond he and Howie formed—which in turn represents the friendships other Indigenous children were able to form even amid the horrors of the residential school system. Likewise, it's a testament to the love they have for their family that Mae and Charlie break the law to rescue Howie. It's clear from Howie's question that he, like Lucy, still feels like part of him is stuck in the mission school. Clara's story about Mariah suggests that it's possible to find peace—but that it requires more than a little luck and hard work.



CHAPTER 14: KENNY

Kenny wakes up, massively hung over, in a flophouse with a strange woman. He digs a relatively clean shirt from the pile of clothes he keeps in a black trash bag, gets dressed, and stumbles to the Two Jays Café for some coffee. As he revives himself with caffeine, he peruses the newspaper. An article describing the lawsuit victims of the residential school system are bringing against the Canadian government catches his eye. He carefully tears it out, pockets it, pays for his coffee, and heads to a payphone to call Lucy. She tells him to come over, even though it means he'll have to face his angry daughter Kendra.

Kendra berates Kenny for continually abandoning her and Lucy. Lucy protects Kenny by sending Kendra out for the day. She puts Kenny into a hot bath, brings him clean clothes, and cooks him food. As he eats, they marvel at how much time has passed. Kendra is now 23 and in college. Kenny shows Lucy the article about the lawsuit. She doesn't think that it will change anything. It certainly can't go back and undo the damage of the past. But Kenny is curious, and he plans to go to the Friendship Center to see if Clara knows anything about it.

The story skips forward many years, although it doesn't reveal that until it becomes clear that Kendra is now an adult. In this way, it suggests how deep and lingering Kenny's wounds are—they persist through time. But although some things have stayed the same, others have changed. The lawsuit suggests that public perspectives about the residential school system have shifted in the decades since Kenny and the others got out. The book's final chapters will explore the promises—and limitations—of these attempts at finding justice.



Kendra's anger points toward the long shadow cast by the residential schools. Kenny's time there damaged him. It also damaged his mother Bella and his relationship with her. And it's damaged Kenny's relationship with his own family—Lucy and Kendra. Still, it's not all bad. Lucy's stability and Kenny's financial support have given Kendra a much better childhood and opportunities than they had—even if it hasn't been perfect.



That evening, Kenny and Kendra have a few minutes to talk privately when Lucy steps out of the house to buy cream. Kendra is still angry, but now she's willing to talk to Kenny. She spent the day at the Friendship Center. While she was there, Clara told her some things about the residential school—and about Kenny's escape attempts—that have given her more insight. She encourages her parents to attend a meeting about the survivors' lawsuit.

At the meeting one of the lawyers representing the survivors expresses his confidence that they will win. He invites anyone who wants to participate to speak with him privately afterwards. Kenny puts his name on the list. While he waits to be called, he wonders how many of the attendees he knows but doesn't recognize from his time at the school. He remembers running into Wilfred. And then Howie comes up to him, drawing him into an embrace and struggling to hold back sobs.

Clara, Lucy, Howie, and Kenny chitchat for a few minutes before the lawyer calls Kenny. He spends half an hour rehashing his most painful memories in detail with the lawyer. The experience is so upsetting that he vomits afterwards, and he can't wait to get out of the Friendship Center. He declines Lucy's offer to go home and puts her onto a bus before going out and drinking himself into a blackout.

In the morning, the sound of someone opening the door wakes Kenny. Surprisingly, he feels good. Better than good: he feels twenty years younger, and the incessant pain of his dying liver has vanished. But then he realizes his perspective is skewed. He seems to be looking down on himself as two paramedics put his body on a stretcher. Then Bella is at his side, explaining how he will pass into the afterlife. Kenny can see his village as it was when he was a child, before he and the others were taken. Then other scenes from the past begin to flash through his mind: memories of the Indian School, Kendra as a baby, the logging camps, and Lucy in her kitchen.

Earlier, Lucy warned Kenny that he'd owe Kendra an explanation. Getting one—even though it comes from Clara, not her father—does soften her anger a little bit. She starts to see what readers already know, that Kenny has done the best he could despite the horrific things that happened to him—things that made him into the man he is now.



Kenny and the others were taken from their families during a period of so many separations that it's been retroactively named the "Sixties Scoop." As Kenny looks around the room, his musings suggest both the breadth and depth of this communal trauma. So many kids were taken, it's impossible for him to know them all. And some of them, like Kenny, were so changed by their trauma that they became unrecognizable to themselves and others.



As elsewhere, the book here hints at the trauma its characters suffered instead of putting it on full display for readers. The book, in short, asks readers to trust victims' pain without tokenizing it. And it's clear from his reaction that whatever Kenny isn't saying directly in front of readers is truly awful.



Like Maisie, Kenny dies without finding redemption. But this extended scene of his passage into the afterlife shows him finding peace, which comes through the restoration of everything that was taken from him when the authorities kidnapped him as a child. This isn't to say that there weren't moments of happiness and peace in his life. But this passage suggests that nothing in life could have been enough to make up for what the residential school from him.



When Kenny's mind settles, he's watching Lucy identify his body in the morgue. The authorities won't let her touch him, but she insists on being given space to say goodbye. Kenny calls out that he's okay, and she seems to hear him. After she leaves, Kenny turns to the spirit of his mother, Bella. She apologizes for the despair-fueled alcoholism that caused her to neglect him after he came home. He tells her that he never blamed her; they were all victims of the residential school system. On the fourth day, Bella instructs Kenny to turn back toward the village. It seems more substantial now. A line of drummers sing a travelling song for him there as he watches his funeral take place in the living world. He catches Lucy's tears in his incorporeal hands and holds them in his hand as he departs.

Lucy must fight to claim Kenny's—and her own—human dignity even after his death. The medical examiner's staff treat her with suspicion rather than kindness. But she refuses to let them dictate who she and Kenny are allowed to be, and thus shows off her own strength and hard-earned sense of self-worth. Tragically, Bella didn't find a similar sense of possibility until after her death but demonstrates her own strength by taking responsibility for how her actions harmed Kenny. Importantly, Kenny reminds her—and readers—that the true blame lies in the system that harmed both. She is a much a victim as him, or Lucy, or even Kendra.



CHAPTER 15: LUCY

One month after Kenny's funeral, Lucy receives a document informing her that she is the beneficiary of a \$300,000 life insurance policy Kenny had. It's just another example of how much he loved Lucy and Kendra. Lucy tells Kendra this and tells her how the abuse he suffered at the residential school permanently damaged him. Afterward, she goes to her bedroom to look at the few photographs she has of Kenny: one from their City Hall wedding, one of him standing outside her old apartment, one of him holding baby Kendra. She weeps.

Kenny couldn't be present in Lucy's or Kendra's life in the way he wanted to be—or that they might have wanted him to be—but that doesn't mean that he didn't love them. His insurance policy demonstrates his care. And it also testifies to how hard he worked throughout his life. He couldn't fully recover from what he suffered at the school, but his sacrifices mean a better life for Lucy and Kendra.



Clara comes over later that day. Like Kendra, she's surprised and impressed by this evidence of Kenny's love. She calls the insurance company to find out what Lucy needs to do next. She reminds Lucy that she'll need to take her ID with her to get her check. Then, the two women tell Kendra the story of the fake IDs they used to get on welfare. Lucy uses the money to put a down payment on a nice house in the neighborhood as an investment for Kendra's future. But she refuses to leave her little rented house because she can't walk away from the memories it holds.

Outside of the residential school, Lucy worked hard to make a family and a home where she—and the people she loved—could feel safe and secure. Her ability to do so testifies to her loving nature and her reserves of strength and courage. She's come a long way from the terrified new mother using a fake ID to get on welfare. Her unwillingness to leave the house reminds readers of her deep and abiding affection for Kenny. It's also a heartbreaking reminder of how many things she's lost in her life. Her home and her memories are one thing she will not willingly give up.



CHAPTER 16: HOWIE

Five years to the day after Sagastis's death, Howie and his relatives finally place a headstone on her grave. Afterwards, Howie plants **tiger lilies** next to the headstone while he thinks about her. He turned down her last offer to visit him in prison, feeling guilty about the toll the long trip took on her health. Now he wishes he'd taken her up on it. When he's done with the flowers, Howie drives back to his mother's place, which he has been fixing up. He sorts through a box of her memorabilia, finding pictures from his sixth birthday celebration at Auntie Mae's and a tiny red car left over from the set she gave him. He also finds a thick folder containing carbon copies of all the letters his mother sent to the RCMP, the Indian Agency, and the mission school itself, begging for them to give him back.

Finding the letters reignites the rage that has burned in Howie's chest since Kenny's funeral. It was that rage that drove him to join the survivors' lawsuit lawyers. At the time, he told Clara that he was doing it less for himself than for those like Kenny—and Lily—whose stories would otherwise remain untold. Now he thinks of Clara wistfully. To distract himself, he gets back to work on tending the garden and building his corral. As soon as possible, he plans to get himself some Appaloosa horses, his favorites since childhood.

In town the next day, Howie finds a letter from Clara waiting for him at the post office. She says she will be in Saskatchewan to visit Mariah in the fall and that she hopes she can see him, too. Over the rest of the summer, as they write letters back and forth, Howie works double time to fix up Sagastis's place, using some of her \$6,000 life savings. Her neighbor Maggie tells Howie that she bought little and leaned on what she could grow, hunt, or trap so that she could save as much as possible of her small government pension. Before Howie knows it, the bright leaves of fall are beginning to grace the trees.

One bright fall morning, Howie packs up and drives south to the city of Regina to meet Clara—and to give his statement in the survivors' lawsuit to a judge. His reunion with Clara is peaceful and joyous. She catches him up on news of Lucy and Kendra. He tells her about fixing up his mom's place and invites her to come and see it. She agrees. She also agrees to attend his testimony as a support person. Much to his surprise, the hearing happens in a hotel conference room. He tells his story in detail, and he speaks at length about his friend Kenny. Afterward, he feels almost euphoric with relief. Clara drives him back to George and Vera's new place and presents him with a dog, one of John Lennon's grandchildren.

Like the other characters in the book, circumstances in Howie's life prevent him from ever recapturing the feeling of home and safety he had as a child. Some things, once destroyed, cannot be replaced or repaired. Still, by returning to Saskatchewan, he does finally complete the journey he started so many years ago, when he was just five years old. The home he returns to isn't the home he left. But he's not the little boy who left, either, and so he sets about doing what he and the others have always done: he makes the best of his circumstances, and he figures out a way to make what is available into what he needs.



Once many years ago, Howie's rage got the best of him and landed him in prison for beating Brother. Many years of hard life lessons—and gentle encouragement from Clara—guide him now as he decides to channel his rage away from destructive acts and into the lawsuit—a cause that will benefit not just himself but others—and into making the home that society denied him for so many years.



The hardworking, conscientiously saving characters in this book quietly correct negative stereotypes about Indigenous people's inability to take care of themselves. Despite the horrors visited on them by the authorities, each of the characters in this book makes a decent life for him- or herself. And although the death of Howie's mother extended his separation from her, he still finds meaning in forging relationships with other people, like Maggie, who can become members of his chosen family.



It's clear as soon as Howie and Clara reunite in this moment that they're meant to be together. They have helped each other so much over the previous few years as they've worked to build meaningful lives for themselves out of the rubble of their childhood traumas. It's not yet time for her to join Howie on his homestead—she still has unfinished business of her own to iron out at Mariah's. But sending the puppy ahead of her foreshadows her desire and intent to join Howie sooner or later.



CHAPTER 17: CLARA

After bidding Howie goodbye, Clara heads to Mariah's cabin. Mariah greets her with a marvelous feast. They talk about George and Vera and their babies—something Mariah encourages Clara to think about before it's too late—and about Clara's work with the courts. Clara says that she's come to see her work the way Rose did. It's still hurtful to experience prejudice from judges and other officials, but she's proud of keeping "Indians out of jail" and helping them to make good lives for themselves. Including Howie. Or maybe especially Howie. She tells Mariah that she has feelings for him, but that they're complicated by their shared residential school trauma.

Clara has come a long way over the years, and she finds a lot of meaning in her work as an advocate. But her life isn't complete yet—and it won't be until she follows through on her feelings for Howie. But this, like everything else in her life, is complicated by her trauma. Clara's relationship with Lucy—like Kenny's—is characterized by periods of intimacy and periods of separation. This points to one of the sources of Clara's childhood suffering: the loss of Lily, whom she loved but wasn't able to save. It's clear that Howie wants a deeper and more permanent relationship with Clara, but for that to work, she must get over her the fear, anger, and guilt she feels when she thinks of Lily—and which makes her afraid of intimacy with others.



In the morning, Clara asks Mariah to help her get her mind and heart clear about Howie in the sweat lodge. She gives Mariah her offerings and Mariah prays over them in Cree. The two women spend the next four nights in the sweat lodge. After the first three visits, Clara dreams only about the abuse she suffered. But after the fourth night, Lily—healthy and resplendent in a beaded dress—appears in her dream. Lily honors Clara's love, care, and protection, assuring her that she bears no blame for Lily's death. Clara sees herself as a child, too, and in the dream, she embraces Lily happily.

Once Clara resisted the sweat lodge and what it represented. She's come a long way since those days, but this doesn't mean that healing is easy or automatic. The trauma she suffered is deep, and it isn't easy to unwind. Still, Clara's determination serves her well in this instance. She finds peace when she realizes that she bears no guilt for what happened to her—or others—in the school. She is nothing but a victim of others' abuse and terror.



In the morning, Mariah instantly knows that Clara has finally found her peace. The rest of the visit passes uneventfully, full of long walks through the groves of poplar and **birch** trees that surround the cabin. At the end of the week, Clara returns to Vancouver. She tells Lucy she's made up her mind: she's going to make a life with Howie.

Mariah knows Clara as intimately as anyone; it's necessary to have a family's love and support, but nothing says that that family has to be made up of blood relatives. Having been loved and mothered through her grief, Clara is now ready to make a new family of her own with Howie.



CHAPTER 18: HOWIE

After giving his testimony, Howie goes home and settles in for the winter, with some help from Maggie. Months later, a letter arrives from the lawyers, telling him how much compensation he will receive. It takes him four days to even be willing to open the envelope.

For the first time in his life, Howie has a safe place to go after he gives his harrowing testimony. He sinks into his house through the winter, letting the quiet and peace there work on healing him. It's good that he has found this peace, too, because although the monetary compensation is a bonus, it can't truly redress the harm he suffered.



In the spring, Howie thoroughly cleans and spruces up the house before Clara's arrival. She approves of the hard work he put in finishing the corral. And she likes the two horses he keeps there—one for him and one for her. That night, after he's fallen asleep, Clara sits at the kitchen table thinking about Maisie's death, Lucy's obsessiveness, and Kenny's compulsive need to run away. When she thinks of Lily, she now sees the happy girl from her dream. She digs into her bag to retrieve the three glass bottles Mariah gave her at the end of their first winter together, so many years earlier. She carries them to the three poplar trees which stand next to the house and suspends them from the branches with their hide ties. Then she slips back into Howie's bed and falls asleep as the bottles' tinkling sound welcomes her home.

Howie's home isn't complete until he has someone—Clara—to share it with. And for the first time in her life, Clara feels like she's truly ready to put down her own roots with Howie, so she hangs up the windchimes and welcomes the spirits which used to sing to her in her childhood (and at Mariah's cabin) back into her life. But Clara's and Howie's happy ending is balanced against the tragedies of Maisie's and Kenny's deaths—and the many smaller ways in which survivors of the residential schools endure ongoing trauma, like Lucy's obsessive counting. Thus the book holds out hope for redemption while also reminding readers that it isn't an easy—or assured—path. This, in turn, keeps a focus on the guilt of those who created, perpetuated, and tolerated the systems of oppression that touched so many Indigenous people's lives. It also pointedly reminds readers that there are some crimes that cannot be recompensed, but only acknowledged and honored.





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